A doctoral thesis



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Imaginal Humanism, the Matricidal Archive, and the Chrysalid Wild Card in Atlus's *Persona* Series, 1996–2024

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Atlus's *Persona* series (1996–2024) constitutes the most sustained popular-philosophical experiment of the past three decades in what it terms **imaginal humanism**: the proposition that the human is neither an essence to be recovered (Renaissance and Enlightenment humanism), nor a void to be self-authored (Sartrean existentialism), nor a discursive fiction to be dissolved (structuralist antihumanism), but a metamorphic capacity—exercised in an intermediate world of images, the Velvet Room that Igor locates "between dream and reality, mind and matter"—to become oneself through the masks of others.

Reading the five principal cycles of the series (*Revelations: Persona*; *Persona 2: Innocent Sin* and *Eternal Punishment*; *Persona 3* with *FES*, *Portable*, *Reload* and *Episode Aigis*; *Persona 4* and *Golden*; *Persona 5* and *Royal*) against their acknowledged and unacknowledged sources—Jung and his Japanese mediator Kawai Hayao, Watsuji Tetsurō's ethics of betweenness (*aidagara*), Doi Takeo's dialectic of *omote* and *ura*, Yogācāra Buddhism and the Kyoto School, Gnostic heresiology, Lovecraftian cosmicism, the *Kojiki*, Goethe's *Faust*, Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*, the European picaresque, and the esoteric tarot painted by Pamela Colman Smith and Frieda Harris—it reconstructs four operators through which the series thinks: the **Mask** (*persona*, *larva*, *prosōpon*) as expressive interface rather than concealing façade; the **Bond** (Social Link, Confidant) as transindividual medium of recognition; the **Wager**, a recurrent cosmological bet between paired powers over the worth of humanity, here named *ludic anthropodicy*; and **Metamorphosis**, the temporal form of the school year as rite of passage.

Against this reconstruction, a second, critical argument identifies the series' constitutive occlusion, here called the **matricidal archive**. Across thirty years the feminine is installed as origin and apocalypse (Pandora, Nyx, Izanami, the murdered researcher Wakaba Isshiki), as medial instrument (the navigators, read through Toni Wolff's typology of the

"medial woman"), and as pupal casing (attendants, gynoids, dolls). This structure reproduces inside the fiction the Matilda effect that governs the series' own intellectual genealogy, from Sabina Spielrein's under-acknowledged anticipation of the death drive to the under-credited women who painted its tarot. Developing a method of **onomastic reading**, the dissertation shows that the mythic names of the Personas—Yamato-Takeru, who crossed gender to conquer; Kanzeon, who changed gender across Asia; Metis, swallowed so that Athena might be born; Amaterasu, whom Hiratsuka Raichō reclaimed in 1911 as the self-luminous woman—harbor a feminist and queer counter-narrative that the scripts disavow. The series' own prescription, that the Shadow once acknowledged becomes power, is thereby turned upon the series itself.

The result is an original theoretical proposal, **chrysalid humanism**. Drawing on the entomological lexicon embedded in the Western vocabulary of selfhood (*larva* as mask and ghost, *pupa* as girl and doll, *imago* as ancestral death-mask, *psychē* as butterfly and soul), on Apuleius's tale of Psyche as the counter-myth of female individuation, and on the developmental biology of histolysis and imaginal discs, it defines the human as the capacity to dissolve one's form in relation and to be recomposed by the imaginal presence of others—a process that requires protected opacity rather than enforced transparency. The dissertation concludes by reconstructing the series' unrealized protagonist, the **chrysalid Wild Card**, prefigured in Maya Amano, Aigis, Elizabeth, the heroine of *Persona 3 Portable*, and Sumire Yoshizawa, as the figure through which the series' humanism might be completed rather than repeated.



Ut comoedi, moniti ne in fronte appareat pudor, personam induunt: sic ego, hoc mundi theatrum conscensurus, in quo hactenus spectator exstiti, larvatus prodeo.

As comic actors, warned lest shame show on their brow, put on a mask, so I, about to mount this theater of the world in which I have hitherto been a spectator, advance masked.

René Descartes, *Cogitationes privatae* (1619), AT X, 213

Alles, was tief ist, liebt die Maske.

Everything profound loves the mask.

Friedrich Nietzsche, *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (1886), §40

元始、女性は実に太陽であった。

In the beginning, woman was truly the sun.

Hiratsuka Raichō, inaugural manifesto of *Seitō* (September 1911)

Note on Corpus, Editions, Nomenclature, and Method

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises *Revelations: Persona* (1996; PSP remake 2009); *Persona 2: Innocent Sin* (1999; PSP 2011) and *Eternal Punishment* (2000; PSP 2012); *Persona 3* (2006), *FES* (2007), *Portable* (2009), *Reload* (2024) and *Episode Aigis* (2024); *Persona 4* (2008) and *Golden* (2012); *Persona 5* (2016) and *Royal* (2019). Spin-offs (*Persona 4 Arena* and *Ultimax*, *Persona Q*, *Persona 5 Strikers*, *Persona 5 Tactica*) are invoked only where they complete a canonical arc, principally Elizabeth's search for the sealed protagonist of *Persona 3* and the figures of Labrys and Sophia. Authorship is treated as collective and institutional: the first two cycles bear the imprint of director Kouji Okada, writer Tadashi Satomi and designer Kazuma Kaneko; the third through fifth that of director Katsura Hashino and character designer Shigenori Soejima. "The series" therefore designates a corporate-collective enunciation, not an auteur, and its contradictions are read as symptoms of that collectivity rather than as lapses of a single intention.

Nomenclature. Silent protagonists are designated functionally ("the *P3* protagonist") or, where clarity requires, by the names fixed in official adaptations (Makoto Yuki, Yu Narukami, Ren Amamiya). Game characters appear in localized Western order; Japanese scholars and historical figures appear in Japanese order (Watsuji Tetsurō, Kawai Hayao, Doi Takeo) except where their translated works have fixed Western order (Hiroki Azuma, Tamaki Saitō). Game dialogue is cited sparingly and in brief fragments; elsewhere it is paraphrased. Unattributed translations are the author's.

Method. Four procedures interlock. (1) *Procedural hermeneutics*: following Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric (2007), Sicart's ethics of play (2009) and Juul's "half-real" (2005), mechanics—the calendar, social statistics, fusion, negotiation, Shuffle Time, the approval meter—are read

as arguments, and ludonarrative dissonance (Hocking 2007) is treated not as a defect but as a symptom. (2) *Onomastic reading*: the compendium of Personas is treated as the series' literal collective unconscious, an archive of mythic potentials (a "database," in Azuma's sense) whose names carry meanings the scripts do not authorize; the method adapts Jung's *amplification* and Freud's attention to the parapraxis. (3) *Comparative mythography and intellectual history*: motifs are traced to source traditions with attention to routes of transmission (Jung via Kawai; tarot via the Golden Dawn and Crowley). (4) *Feminist, queer and decolonial critique*: Irigaray, Kristeva, Butler, Sedgwick, Mulvey, Haraway, Cavarero, Ueno and Glissant supply the instruments by which the series is read against itself. The governing ethic of the method is borrowed from the corpus: neither condemnation nor celebration, but the acknowledgment that, in the series' own terms, converts a Shadow into a Persona.

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Introduction: The Mask That Thinks

I. The founding inversion

The persona in *Persona* does not conceal; it discloses. This inversion is the series' founding philosophical act. For Jung, the persona is a segment of the collective psyche that feigns individuality, a compromise between individual and society concerning how one ought to appear; individuation requires that the ego dis-identify from it (Jung 1928, CW 7 §§245–246). In the series, by contrast, the Persona is summoned precisely when the social façade fails: it rises from the acknowledged Shadow (*P4*), from the resolve to look death in the face (*P3*), from the refusal of servitude (*P5*). The series thereby transvalues Jung's term, aligning it less with Jung's persona than with Wilde's paradox in "The Critic as Artist" (1891)—"Give him a mask, and he will tell you the truth"—and with Yeats's doctrine of the Mask as anti-self, the image of what one is not and must become ("Per Amica Silentia Lunae," 1917). This dissertation takes that transvaluation as its point of departure and asks what conception of the human it entails.

II. A genealogy of the mask

The word itself already gathers the registers the series will rejoin. The most probable etymon of Latin *persona* is Etruscan *φersu*, the masked figure painted in the Tomb of the Augurs at Tarquinia (late sixth century BCE), who presides over a lethal game in which a dog is set upon a hooded man. The folk etymology *per-sonare*, "to sound through," transmitted by Aulus Gellius from Gavius Bassus (*Noctes Atticae* 5.7), is philologically doubtful but philosophically fertile, since it makes the mask an instrument of voice. From its first appearance, then, *persona* binds mask, game and death—the triad of *Persona 3*, whose summoning device mimes suicide: a pistol held to one's own temple.

Roman law converted the theatrical mask into the bearer of rights; Trinitarian theology converted it into *hypostasis*; and Boethius sealed the conversion of mask into substance with his definition of the person as "an individual substance of rational nature" (*Contra Eutychen* III, c. 512). Marcel Mauss's celebrated lecture (1938) traced this long passage from *personnage* through *persona* and *personne* to the modern *moi*. The *Persona*

series, it will be argued, runs Mauss's sequence backward: it begins with the bourgeois *moi* of the Japanese high-school student and returns it, by way of the summoned mask, to the *personnage*—the role received from a cosmos of others.

Modern philosophy begins masked. In a private notebook of 1619 the young Descartes writes that, like actors who put on a *persona* lest their blush be seen, he advances onto the world's stage *larvatus*—masked. The Latin *larva* means at once mask, ghost and (since Linnaeus) the immature form of an insect, a semantic knot this dissertation will untie in its final chapter. The Renaissance humanists had already thought the human through masks before the Enlightenment thought it through dignity. Pico della Mirandola's God gives Adam no fixed seat or form, so that he may fashion himself into whatever shape he prefers, and Pico exclaims, *quis hunc nostrum chamaeleonta non admiretur?* (*Oratio*, 1486). Erasmus's Folly —who is, after all, the Fool—observes that life is a play in which everyone wears a mask, and that whoever strips the masks from the actors ruins the play (*Moriae Encomium*, 1511, §29). Montaigne concludes that "we are all patchwork" (*Essais* II.1). Pico's chameleon, Erasmus's Fool and Montaigne's patchwork together describe, with uncanny precision, the Wild Card: the Fool of Arcana 0 who can bear any mask because he has no fixed form.

Two twentieth-century theorists complete the genealogy. Watsuji Tetsurō's essay "Men to perusona" ("Mask and Persona," 1935) argues from the Noh mask that the face is the seat of the person, and that the person is constituted not inside the individual but in the space between persons. Hannah Arendt, from the opposite direction, defends the persona as the legal mask that protects the vulnerable "natural man," and indicts the revolutionary passion for unmasking hypocrites, which in Robespierre's hands became terror (*On Revolution*, 1963, ch. 2). Yet Arendt also supplies, in *The Human Condition* (1958, §24), the single most exact gloss on the series' iconography: the unique "who" that a person discloses in speech and action remains hidden from that person and is visible only to others, like the Greek *daimōn* who accompanies each human through life looking over his shoulder from behind. The summoned Persona—materializing behind its user, visible to companions

and enemies but never quite to its bearer—is Arendt's daimon rendered as image.

III. State of the question

The philosophical turn in game studies (Bogost 2007; Sicart 2009; Juul 2005; Galloway 2006) has equipped criticism to read mechanics as arguments; Japanese media theory (Ōtsuka 1989; Azuma 2001; Saitō 2000; Steinberg 2012; Allison 2006, 2013) has situated the medium within post-1995 Japan; feminist and queer game studies (Shaw 2014; Ruberg 2019; Sarkeesian 2013–2017) have exposed the gendered grammars of play; and feminist revisions of Jung (Wehr 1987; Rowland 2002) have contested the archetype as ahistorical essence. Criticism of the *Persona* series itself remains dispersed across journal articles, conference papers, developer interviews and an unusually sophisticated body of fan scholarship. To the author's knowledge, no sustained study has integrated its Jungian, Japanese-philosophical, esoteric, mythographic and feminist dimensions, or treated the series as a philosophical apparatus rather than an illustration of borrowed doctrine. This dissertation proposes such an integration.

IV. Thesis

The argument advances five claims.

1. **Imaginal humanism.** The series articulates a humanism of metamorphosis in which the human is the capacity to become oneself through the masks of others, within an intermediate imaginal space—Henry Corbin's *mundus imaginalis* (1964), staged as the Velvet Room.
2. **Four operators.** This humanism is generated by the Mask (expressive interface), the Bond (transindividual recognition), the Wager (ludic anthropodicy) and Metamorphosis (the school year as rite of passage).
3. **The matricidal archive.** The series' humanism rests on a constitutive occlusion of the feminine as origin, apocalypse, medium and casing,

which reproduces within the fiction the erasures that structure the series' own intellectual genealogy.

4. **The onomastic unconscious.** The mythic names of the Personas encode feminist and queer counter-narratives that the scripts disavow; the compendium is the series' Shadow.
5. **Chrysalid humanism.** Acknowledging that Shadow yields a new theory of the human, organized around the pupa rather than the larva or the imago, and around Psyche rather than Orpheus, in which the site of transformation is recognized as its agent and opacity as its condition.

V. Plan of the work

Part One (Chapters 1–2) reconstructs the series' sources: the Jungian substrate and its Japanese mediation by Kawai, Doi, Watsuji, Yogācāra and the Kyoto School; then the esoteric, Gnostic, Lovecraftian, mythographic and literary archive. Part Two (Chapters 3–6) reads each cycle as a distinct philosophical anthropology: an ontology of rumor (*P1–P2*), a thanatology (*P3*), an epistemology (*P4*) and a politics (*P5*). Part Three (Chapters 7–9) advances the critical arguments: the matricidal archive, the instrumental bond, and ludic anthropodicy. Part Four (Chapter 10 and the Conclusion) constructs chrysalid humanism and reconstructs the series' unrealized protagonist.

I



Part One: Genealogies

The Jungian Substrate and Its Japanese Mediation

1.1 Jung's topography and its transvaluation

The series borrows Jung's psychic topography wholesale and then rearranges its furniture. Jung's persona is the adaptive façade; the Shadow, the "moral problem that challenges the whole ego-personality" (*Aion*, CW 9ii §14), is the inferior and repressed; the anima and animus are contrasexual figures mediating the unconscious; the Self is the totality and its archetype is the *coincidentia oppositorum*. Individuation proceeds by withdrawing projections, integrating the Shadow, relativizing the ego before the Self. The series retains the vocabulary—the "sea of souls" is the collective unconscious, the Shadow is the repressed, the Velvet Room's attendants are anima-figures, Philemon is a figure of the Self—but its decisive move is to make the persona the instrument of individuation rather than its obstacle. Jung's persona is what must be seen through; the series' Persona is what one sees with.

Three consequences follow. First, the Persona is *dialogical*: it is born of a confrontation between ego and Shadow that ends not in the Shadow's defeat but in its avowal ("I am thou, thou art I"). Second, it is *plural*: the Wild Card hosts a pantheon, a figure closer to James Hillman's "polytheistic psychology" (*Re-Visioning Psychology*, 1975), with its critique of the monotheism of the ego, than to Jung's unitary Self. Third, it is *relational*: in the games from *P3* onward, the protagonist's Personas grow in proportion to his bonds, so that the archetype becomes a function of sociality. The Wild Card thus recalls not only Jung but the great modern experiments in multiple authorship: Kierkegaard's pseudonyms as indirect communication, Pessoa's heteronyms ("the poet is a feigner," "Autopsicografia," 1932), and Pirandello's Vitangelo Moscarda, who discovers himself to be *one, no one and one hundred thousand* (1926)—one avatar, no voice of his own, and a hundred-odd masks.

1.2 Philemon: Jung's daimon and Faust's guilt

Philemon, who grants the power of the Persona in the first two games and is served by Igor thereafter, is Jung's own spirit-guide from *Liber Novus* (composed 1913–c. 1930; published 2009): a winged old man with whom Jung conversed in active imagination and whom he credited with

teaching him the objective reality of the psyche. The name arrives already laden. In Ovid (*Metamorphoses* VIII), Philemon and Baucis are the poor couple who alone receive the disguised gods with hospitality and are rewarded by being turned into intertwined trees. In Goethe's *Faust II* (Act V) they are burned out of their cottage by the agents of Faust's land-reclamation project. Jung felt Faust's crime as an inherited debt and carved over a door at Bollingen *Philemonis sacrum—Fausti poenitentia*, "Shrine of Philemon, Penance of Faust" (*Memories, Dreams, Reflections*, 1962). The series' Philemon, masked with a butterfly, is thus a figure of hospitality wronged by Promethean modernity, a fitting guardian for games whose first villains are a corporate technocrat (Kandori of SEBEC) and a Faustian wager. The butterfly is not ornament: Greek *psychē* names both soul and butterfly, and Chapter 10 will argue that the series' recurring azure butterfly is the emblem of a story it has not yet told.

1.3 Kawai Hayao and the Japanese domestication of Jung

Jung reached Japan principally through Kawai Hayao (1928–2007), the first Japanese analyst certified at the C. G. Jung Institute in Zürich (1965), later Commissioner for Cultural Affairs. Three of Kawai's theses bear directly on the corpus. *Bosei shakai Nihon no byōri* (*The Pathology of Japan as a Maternal Society*, 1976) contrasts a Japanese "maternal principle" of inclusion and equalization with a Western "paternal principle" of separation and judgment, and diagnoses Japanese pathologies as failures to cut. *Chūkū kōzō Nihon no shinsō* (*The Hollow-Center Structure of Japan's Depths*, 1982) observes that the *Kojiki* repeatedly arranges deities in triads whose middle member is inert—Ame-no-Minakanushi among the first gods; Tsukuyomi between Amaterasu and Susano-o—and proposes the hollow center as a structural principle of the Japanese psyche. *Mukashibanashi to Nihonjin no kokoro* (1982; *The Japanese Psyche*, 1988) reads Japanese folktales against Grimm, isolating the motif of the forbidden look: where the Western hero breaks a taboo and gains, the Japanese man who looks into the forbidden chamber causes the woman to vanish, leaving only *aware*, the pathos of loss. Kawai ends by proposing not the male hero but the "woman of will" as the figure best suited to represent Japanese consciousness.

Each thesis finds a corollary. The silent protagonist is a hollow center: in *P4* he stands, structurally, between Yukiko's Amaterasu and Yosuke's Susano-o, while Tsukuyomi drifts through the compendium as a fusible Moon Persona—the inert middle of the divine siblings. *P4*'s plot is a sustained meditation on the forbidden look, culminating in the defeat of Izanami, the goddess whom Izanagi abandoned after looking upon her corpse. And Kawai's "woman of will" anticipates this dissertation's reconstruction of the chrysalid Wild Card. The mediation carries a liability: Kawai's psychology of "the Japanese" shades into *nihonjinron*, the essentialist discourse of Japanese uniqueness criticized by Peter Dale (1986) and Oguma Eiji (1995). The series inherits both the insight and the essentialism. Kawai's dialogue with Murakami Haruki (1996), conducted as Murakami was interviewing victims of the 1995 sarin attack for *Underground* (1997), situates the whole enterprise within the depth-psychological imaginary of post-1995 Japan: wells, other worlds, and a public newly frightened of the cult and the unconscious.

1.4 *Omote*, *ura* and the dramaturgical self

Doi Takeo's *Amae no kōzō* (1971) and *Omote to ura* (1985) supply the indigenous grammar that the series overlays on Jung. The self is doubled into *omote* (front, face, the public surface) and *ura* (back, lining, the private interior), a structure lived socially as *tatemae* (the stance one professes) and *honne* (what one actually feels). Erving Goffman's dramaturgical sociology ("On Face-Work," 1955; *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, 1959) offers a parallel Western account of front and back stage. The series literalizes this doubling: *P4*'s Shadows are the *ura* broadcast on television; *P5*'s Palaces are the *ura* of adults rendered as architecture. But the Phantom Thieves introduce a third term. Their masks are worn not over the *ura* but over the *omote*: a mask upon the public face that releases the hidden as rebellion. Here Yeats's Mask becomes precise. For Yeats the Mask is the anti-self, the image of what one is not and desires to become; the first Personas of *P5*—Arsène Lupin, Captain Kidd, Carmen, Zorro, Goemon, Pope Joan, Milady—are outlaws whom their bearers are not yet but must become.

1.5 Watsuji's *ningen* and the ethics of betweenness

Watsuji Tetsurō's *Ethics as the Study of Ningen* (1934) and *Rinrigaku* (1937–1949) supply the series' deepest, least acknowledged philosophical anthropology. The Japanese *ningen* (人間) is written "human" plus "between"; Watsuji reads it as a programmatic claim that the human is constituted in *aidagara* (間柄), relational betweenness, and he criticizes Heidegger's *Dasein* for privileging temporality and the solitary confrontation with death over spatiality and the shared world (*Fūdo*, 1935). His essay on masks argues that the Noh mask, nearly expressionless in itself, comes alive only through the actor's tilt and the audience's gaze, so that expression is an event between persons. Zeami had already named the actor's discipline *riken no ken*, "the seeing of detached seeing," by which the performer sees himself from the place of the audience (*Kakyō*, 1424).

The Social Link is *aidagara* made procedural. The Arcana are not traits of the protagonist but properties of relationships; his power grows only through betweenness, and in *P3* his final power, the Universe, is literally the sum of his bonds. Yet Watsuji's *Rinrigaku* culminates in the state as the highest ethical totality, and during the Pacific War he wrote in direct support of the imperial order, presenting reverence for the emperor as the core of Japan's ethical tradition (*Sonnō shisō to sono dentō*, 1943); his ethics of betweenness served wartime nationalism (Sakai 1997). The series' ethic of betweenness must therefore be protected from Watsuji's totalism, and *P5* performs that protection by making the state, personified in Shido, the final human antagonist: betweenness against the nation.

1.6 Yogācāra and the Kyoto School

Beneath Jung lies an older psychology. Yogācāra Buddhism, systematized by Asaṅga and Vasubandhu (fourth–fifth centuries), posits an *ālaya-vijñāna*, a "storehouse consciousness" holding the karmic seeds (*bīja*) from which experienced worlds arise; its doctrine of *vijñaptimātra* ("representation-only") holds that the world as experienced is constructed by cognition. *Persona 2* names its pivotal site the Alaya Shrine; the later games' "sea of souls" is a storehouse consciousness in all

but name. Yogācāra's three natures map with startling exactness onto *P5*. Each Palace is *parikalpita*, the imagined nature: a world falsely constructed by a distorted cognition. It rests on *paratantra*, the dependent nature: real causal processes of desire and power. The Treasure is the *bīja*, the seed of distortion. And the change of heart is *āśraya-parāvṛtti*, the "revolution of the basis" by which consciousness is transformed at its root.

The Kyoto School supplies the series' metaphysics of the zero. Nishida Kitarō's "place of absolute nothingness" (*basho*, 1926) and Nishitani Keiji's account of a field of emptiness (*śūnyatā*) that lies beyond the field of nihility (*Religion and Nothingness*, 1961) give philosophical form to the Fool's Arcanum 0: an emptiness that is not lack but capacity. Zen had long pointed to this with the koan of the "original face" before one's parents were born (*Mumonkan*, case 23, 1228). The question that will govern this dissertation's conclusion is whether, beneath the masks, the series finds such an original face, or only another mask, or—as Chapter 10 proposes—something else entirely: not a face but a metamorphosis.

II



Part One: Genealogies

The Esoteric, Mythographic, and Literary Archive

2.1 Tarot as narrative grammar

The Major Arcana reach the series through three historical strata. The first is Antoine Court de Gébelin's fantasy of an Egyptian *Book of Thoth* (*Le Monde primitif*, 1781) and Éliphas Lévi's correlation of the twenty-two trumps with the Hebrew alphabet (1850s). The second is the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, whose members produced the two decks that dominate modern practice: the Rider–Waite–Smith deck (1909), designed by A. E. Waite and painted by Pamela Colman Smith, and the Thoth deck, conceived by Aleister Crowley and painted by Lady Frieda Harris (1938–1943, published 1969). The third is the Jungian appropriation of tarot as an archetypal map of individuation—the "Fool's Journey" popularized by Eden Gray in the 1960s and systematized in Sallie Nichols's *Jung and Tarot* (1980). The series draws on all three, and its debts to the Thoth line are legible in its nomenclature: the Aeon (Aigis in *P3 FES*, Marie in *P4 Golden*) is Crowley's renaming of Judgement, and the Universe, the terminal power of *P3*, is Crowley's renaming of the World.

Structurally, the series treats the Arcana as Vladimir Propp treated the functions of the Russian wonder-tale (*Morphology of the Folktale*, 1928): as a finite grammar of narrative positions that any character may occupy. Its additions—the Jester and Aeon (*P4 Golden*), Faith and Councillor (*P5 Royal*)—show the canon to be open, a grammar that can be extended when a new relation demands a new position. A feminist footnote belongs in the main text: the two decks from which the series' iconography descends were painted by women whose authorship was long effaced by the convention of naming decks for men ("the Rider–Waite"). The series' arcane grammar thus arrives already marked by the pattern this dissertation will call the matricidal archive.

2.2 Gnosis: the Demiurge and the prison

P5's final antagonist, Yaldabaoth, descends from the *Apocryphon of John*, recovered among the Nag Hammadi codices (1945). There Sophia, divine Wisdom, conceives without her consort; her offspring is a lion-faced serpent who, ignorant of his origin, proclaims himself the only god and fashions the material world as a prison of archons. *P5* transposes this

cosmology with precision: the Velvet Room has become a prison, its master impersonated by the Demiurge; humanity has delivered itself to a God of Control through the Holy Grail of its collective wish; and the protagonist's ultimate Persona is Satanael, the elder son of God in Bogomil dualism, who rebels against the order of the world. Hans Jonas ("Gnosticism and Modern Nihilism," 1952; *The Gnostic Religion*, 1958) argued that ancient Gnosticism and modern existentialism share a single experience of cosmic alienation; *P5* fuses them, making the trickster's revolt against the Demiurge an existentialist gnosis. Eric Voegelin's warning against modern political "gnosticism"—movements in which an elect, possessing saving knowledge, undertakes to transform the world by acting directly on souls (*The New Science of Politics*, 1952)—describes the Phantom Thieves' method uncomfortably well, and Chapter 6 will show that the game knows it.

The transposition also performs a deletion. In the *Apocryphon*, the Demiurge's existence is blamed on a woman's unauthorized creativity; in *P5*, Sophia vanishes altogether, and feminine wisdom survives only as the attendant Lavenza, split in two by the Demiurge. The series restores the name only in the spin-off *Persona 5 Strikers* (2020), as an artificial girl called Sophia whose Persona is Pandora—Hesiod's first woman, the vessel of all evils, and the final antagonist of *Revelations: Persona*. The circuit from Wisdom to the first woman to the artificial girl is the matricidal archive in miniature.

2.3 Lovecraft: the Outer God turned inward

Nyarlathotep, the Crawling Chaos of Lovecraft's prose poem (1920) and later fiction, is the antagonist of *Persona 2*; Azathoth, the blind idiot god at the center of chaos, is the Persona of *Royal*'s Takuto Maruki; the *Necronomicon*, whose Arabic original Lovecraft named *Al Azif* ("The History of the *Necronomicon*," 1927), is Futaba Sakura's first and final Persona. Lovecraft's cosmicism holds that the universe is indifferent to human meaning; he also held white-supremacist and antisemitic views, expressed in his letters and early verse, and his fiction repeatedly figures horror as racial contamination, most notoriously in the immigrant Brooklyn of "The Horror at Red Hook" (1927) and the hereditary

degeneration of "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936). The series inverts both. Its Nyarlathotep is not an indifferent Outer God but a projection of humanity's own collective unconscious, Philemon's shadow-twin; cosmic horror is psychologized, and the outside is revealed as the inside. Where Lovecraft's cosmos is indifferent, the series' cosmos is a wager on human worth.

2.4 Japanese mythography and the goddess who names the franchise

The macro-franchise to which *Persona* belongs takes its name from Aya Nishitani's novel *Digital Devil Story: Megami Tensei* (1986), whose title ("Reincarnation of the Goddess") refers to its heroine Yumiko Shirasagi as the reincarnated Izanami. The franchise is thus named for a goddess's return, and *P4*'s final antagonist is that goddess: the primordial mother of the *Kojiki* (712), who died giving birth to fire, whom Izanagi looked upon in the underworld against her plea, and who, abandoned and sealed behind a boulder at Yomotsu Hirasaka, vowed to take a thousand lives a day.

The *Kojiki* and *Nihon shoki* (720) supply the substratum of *P4*'s pantheon: Amaterasu and Susano-o, the sun goddess and her unruly brother, whose rampage drove her into the Heavenly Rock Cave; Ame-no-Uzume, whose ecstatic, exposing dance made the gods laugh and drew the sun back into the world; Konohana-sakuya-hime, the blossom princess whose husband Ninigi rejected her rock-sister Iwanaga-hime, thereby making human life brief as flowers; and Yamato-Takeru, the prince who disguised himself as a maiden to assassinate the Kumaso chieftains. These texts were compiled to legitimate the imperial genealogy and were mobilized again in state ideology (*Kokutai no hongi*, 1937). *P4* domesticates the imperial myth into a rural murder mystery, a depoliticization that both defuses and conceals the myth's history. The appropriation extends beyond Yamato: Teddie's ultimate Persona is Kamui, an Ainu term for the divine, borrowed from a people whose land the Meiji state colonized, whom it subjected to forced assimilation under the Hokkaido Former Aborigines Protection Act of 1899, and whom the Japanese state recognized as indigenous only in 2019.

2.5 The Western literary archive: Frankenstein's women

The most consequential literary source has gone largely unremarked in criticism, though it is familiar to fans: the Velvet Room is staffed by the women of Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818), and its master bears the name of the hunchbacked assistant of the film tradition (Ygor in *Son of Frankenstein*, 1939).

Attendant	Game	Figure in *Frankenstein*	Her fate in the novel
Elizabeth	*P3*	Elizabeth Lavenza, Victor's adopted sister and bride	Strangled by the Creature on her wedding night
Margaret	*P4*	Margaret Walton Saville, addressee of Walton's frame letters	Silent recipient; never speaks
Caroline	*P5*	Caroline Beaufort, Victor's mother	Dies nursing Elizabeth through scarlet fever
Justine	*P5*	Justine Moritz, the family's servant	Falsely convicted of murder and executed
Lavenza	*P5*	Surname of Elizabeth Lavenza	(as Elizabeth)

Every woman in the novel dies, is silenced or is executed so that the drama of male creation can proceed. In the series they become the attendants of a laboratory of composite selves, in which Personas are assembled from the remains of others—in *P5*, literally by guillotine, gallows and electric chair. Read through the feminist criticism of Shelley—Ellen Moers's account of *Frankenstein* as a birth myth (*Literary Women*, 1976), Gilbert and Gubar's reading of it as a rewriting of *Paradise Lost* (*The Madwoman in the Attic*, 1979), Anne Mellor's analysis of masculine science's usurpation of female reproduction (1988)—the Velvet Room appears as a site where the male protagonist gives birth to selves, attended by women whose own narrative was death. The genealogy runs further: Mary Shelley was the daughter of Mary Wollstonecraft, whose *Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) founded liberal feminism. The series' imaginal laboratory is staffed, at one remove, by the daughters of the first feminist.

2.6 Wagers, thieves and descents

Three further lineages complete the archive. The *wager*: the Book of Job, in which God and the Satan bet on a righteous man; Goethe's "Prologue in Heaven," in which the Lord and Mephistopheles bet on Faust; and their descendants in the series' paired cosmic powers (Chapter 9). The *thief*: the picaresque from *Lazarillo de Tormes* (1554) through Maurice Leblanc's Arsène Lupin (from 1905), Johnston McCulley's Zorro (1919), the legendary Ishikawa Goemon, Dumas's Milady (1844), Mérimée's and Bizet's Carmen (1845; 1875) and the legend of Pope Joan—outlaws and transgressive women who supply *P5*'s first-tier Personas. The *descent*: Orpheus's journey to retrieve Eurydice (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X), rewritten from Eurydice's side by H.D. (1917), who has her refuse to be the object of Orpheus's rescue and claim a light of her own in Hades. *P3*'s protagonist begins as Orpheus; Chapter 4 will show that the cycle ends by transferring the descent to women.

III



Part Two: Four Anthropologies

Persona 1 and *2*: The Ontology of Rumor and the Founding Wager

Revelations: Persona (1996), *Innocent Sin* (1999), *Eternal Punishment* (2000)

3.1 A game of summoning

The series begins with a game. In the opening of *Revelations: Persona* (1996), students of St. Hermelin High School perform a classroom ritual called "Persona," a variant of *kokkuri-san*, the table-turning divination that entered Japan in the Meiji era, and are visited by Philemon. The founding scene thus stages, within the fiction, Johan Huizinga's thesis that play is older than culture and that its "magic circle" is continuous with ritual (*Homo Ludens*, 1938). The power of the Persona arrives not through ascesis or revelation but through play, and the series never revokes this origin: every subsequent Persona is acquired inside a game the player is playing.

3.2 Maki, Pandora and the first appropriation

The world of *Revelations* is remade by the DEVA System of the SEBEC corporation, through which the executive Takahisa Kandori seeks godhood. Its raw material is the imagination of Maki Sonomura, a chronically ill girl long confined to hospital, whose wish for a healthy life generates an alternate town and splits her psyche into idealized and abject avatars. The apocalypse that issues from her despair is named Pandora.

The structure is exemplary and will recur for thirty years: a young woman's psyche is the substrate of a world, and a man's machine converts it into an instrument of power. The name is equally exact. In Hesiod (*Theogony* 570–612; *Works and Days* 54–105), Pandora is fashioned as Zeus's punishment for Prometheus's theft of fire, a "beautiful evil" (*kalon kakon*) whose jar releases every misery upon men. *Revelations* restages Hesiod's diptych in technological dress: Kandori's machine is the stolen fire, and the catastrophe is attributed to a woman. Jane Ellen Harrison's *Prolegomena to the Study of Greek Religion* (1903) had already proposed that Hesiod's Pandora is the degraded form of an earth goddess, "Anesidora," she who sends up gifts, rewritten by a misogynist theology into the origin of evil. The series' first apocalypse thus bears the name of the first matricide in Western mythography: the conversion of the All-Giver into the All-Blamed.

The optional "Snow Queen" scenario, in which a teacher is possessed by a cursed mask, supplies an unexpected counter-text. In Andersen's tale (1844), a troll's mirror that distorts all it reflects shatters, and its splinters lodge in the eye and heart of the boy Kay, who henceforth sees only ugliness; it is the girl Gerda who journeys to rescue him. Andersen's splinter in the heart is the prototype of *P5*'s distorted cognition, and Gerda is the series' first and most forgotten woman of will.

3.3 Rumor as ontology

Persona 2: Innocent Sin (1999) and *Eternal Punishment* (2000) are set in Sumaru City, where rumors become real. A rumor that calling one's own number summons the Joker becomes a curse; rumors about shops change their wares; a rumor that Nazi remnants survive brings forth the Last Battalion, led by a revived Adolf Hitler styled the Führer; a prophecy, the Oracle of Maia, drives the city toward a Mayan-themed apocalypse in the underworld of Xibalba. The premise radicalizes the Thomas theorem—"if men define situations as real, they are real in their consequences" (Thomas and Thomas 1928)—from a claim about consequences into a claim about being.

The classic sociology of rumor clarifies what the game dramatizes. Allport and Postman (1947) modeled rumor intensity as the product of a matter's importance and its ambiguity; Tamotsu Shibutani (*Improvised News*, 1966) redefined rumor as collective problem-solving under informational scarcity; Jean-Noël Kapferer (1987) called it the oldest medium. Baudrillard's "precession of simulacra" (1981), in which the model precedes and engenders the real, names the endpoint. Sumaru is Baudrillard's hyperreal city given a supernatural mechanism.

The historical frame is precise. *Innocent Sin* appeared in 1999, the year in which a quarter-century of Japanese pop-occultism had placed the end of the world: Gotō Ben's bestseller on Nostradamus (1973) had fixed the prophecy of a "king of terror" descending from the sky in July 1999, and Aum Shinrikyō, the cult led by Asahara Shōkō, whose members released sarin on the Tokyo subway on 20 March 1995, killing fourteen people and injuring thousands, had built its eschatology from that occult bricolage. Japanese urban legend had also long been gendered: the 1979 panic over

the Kuchisake-onna, a masked woman who asks passers-by whether she is beautiful before revealing a mouth slit ear to ear and, in most versions, maiming those who answer wrongly so that they bear the same wound, condensed anxieties about female beauty and female rage into a rumor that wore a mask. *P2* is therefore a critique, from inside the occult boom, of the media ecology that manufactures apocalypse.

Its treatment of fascism belongs to this critique. The Last Battalion is fascism as reified rumor. Arendt argued that the ideal subject of totalitarian rule is not the convinced ideologue but the person for whom the distinction between fact and fiction no longer exists, and that totalitarian movements prefer a consistent fiction to an inconsistent reality (*The Origins of Totalitarianism*, 1951). Sumaru is a city in which that distinction has collapsed ontologically, so that the most consistent fiction literally prevails. The game's rendering of Hitler as a summonable rumor is both its boldest gesture and its most troubling, since it risks converting the Holocaust—the Nazi state's murder of six million Jews, together with Roma, disabled people and others it deemed unworthy of life—into occult spectacle, a risk sharpened by Japan's own wartime alliance with Nazi Germany; its defense is that the game locates fascism's power precisely where Arendt did, in the masses' desire for a total story.

3.4 Masks, cults and the wounded child

The antagonists of *Innocent Sin* are the Masked Circle, led by "Joker," who is revealed to be Jun Kurosu, the protagonist Tatsuya Suou's estranged childhood friend. Elias Canetti observed that the mask separates and fixes, establishing a rigid distance between the wearer and the world (*Crowds and Power*, 1960); the cult's masks collectivize their wearers into an anonymous body. Jun's mask conceals a wounded child, abandoned by a powerful father and bound to Tatsuya by a vow made in childhood. His language of flowers and his devotion to Tatsuya have been widely read as queer, and the game permits an affective choice of Jun at a pivotal moment—an early instance of the series' onomastic and affective unconscious exceeding its normative surface.

Lisa Silverman, raised in Japan by parents of European descent, is perpetually misrecognized as foreign. Her case exposes the racial

essentialism of *nihonjinron*: she is Japanese by language, upbringing and self-understanding, and foreign only in the gaze of others. Frantz Fanon described the moment of being fixed by the colonizing look ("Look, a Negro!") as the experience of being sealed into an objecthood one did not choose (*Black Skin, White Masks*, 1952). Lisa's response is to choose a third identity, the Hong Kong of Bruce Lee, refusing both the foreignness imposed upon her and the Japaneseness demanded of her.

3.5 Forgetting, punishment, and the first woman of will

Innocent Sin ends with the world's destruction and a reset purchased at a terrible price: the protagonists must forget one another. This is the dialectical antithesis of everything that follows. In *P2*, bonds must be sacrificed to save the world; from *P3* onward, bonds are the power that saves it. Nietzsche praised active forgetting as the condition of life (*On the Uses and Disadvantages of History for Life*, 1874), and Ricoeur weighed the "duty of memory" against a "happy forgetting" (*Memory, History, Forgetting*, 2000). *P2* refuses both consolations. In *Eternal Punishment*, set in the reset world, Tatsuya alone remembers, and his punishment is to bear the memory of bonds that no one else shares—memory as isolation.

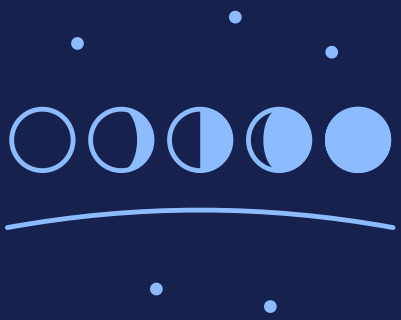
The protagonist of *Eternal Punishment* is Maya Amano, a magazine journalist and the series' first female lead. Her profession, verifying stories, is rumor's antidote; her motto, a cheerful broken-English exhortation to "positive thinking," is easily mistaken for naivety. It is better understood against Sara Ahmed's critique of happiness as a social command (*The Promise of Happiness*, 2010) and Lauren Berlant's "cruel optimism" (2011): Maya's optimism is neither imposed cheer nor attachment to what harms her, but a chosen hope held in full knowledge of a catastrophe she has already suffered—in the other world, she died. She is the first of the women of will whom this dissertation will place at the center of the series' unrealized humanism.

3.6 The founding wager

Behind the plot stands a cosmological bet. Philemon and Nyarlathotep are revealed as twin aspects of humanity's collective unconscious:

Nyarlathotep wagers that humanity, given power over its own reality, will destroy itself; Philemon wagers that it will transcend its weakness. The players are the stake. This structure, inherited from Job and *Faust*, founds what Chapter 9 calls ludic anthropodicy: a justification of humanity that cannot be argued but only played. Its first form, in *P2*, is pessimistic about bonds and optimistic about will; the series will spend the next twenty-five years reversing those signs.

IV



Part Two: Four Anthropologies

Persona 3: Thanatology, the Death Drive, and the Gift of Finitude

Persona 3 (2006), *FES* (2007), *Portable* (2009), *Reload* and *Episode Aigis* (2024)

4.1 The hidden hour and the coffins of *das Man*

Persona 3 (2006) is organized around *memento mori*. Each night contains a hidden twenty-fifth hour, the Dark Hour, in which ordinary people are transmogrified into coffins and remain unaware of the predators that hunt among them, while a school becomes Tartarus, a labyrinthine tower. The image is a near-literal rendering of Heidegger's analysis of everydayness: *das Man*, the anonymous "they," lives in a tranquilized flight from death, and death is the possibility that individualizes because no one can die in my place (*Being and Time*, 1927, §§27, 47–53). The coffined citizens are *das Man* asleep in its own death; the members of SEES are those who have awakened to it.

The daylight symptom of the Dark Hour is Apathy Syndrome: victims, "the Lost," lose the will to act and stand motionless, murmuring. The condition gives clinical form to Kierkegaard's "sickness unto death," the despair of a self unwilling to be itself (1849), and anticipates Byung-Chul Han's diagnosis of depression as the illness of an achievement society whose subjects exhaust themselves in self-optimization (*The Burnout Society*, 2010). It also condenses the Japanese anxieties of the mid-2000s: the social withdrawal Tamaki Saitō named *hikikomori* (1998), the precarity of a generation entering a broken labor market (Allison 2013). The summoning device, the Evoker, is a pistol-shaped instrument that the user fires at their own head: every summoning mimes suicide. The game appeared in July 2006, when Japan had recorded more than 30,000 suicides a year for eight consecutive years, when reports of internet-arranged group suicides among the young had recurred since 2003, and a month after the Diet passed the country's first national suicide-prevention law, the Basic Act on Suicide Countermeasures. The Evoker takes the gesture of self-annihilation that haunted Japanese youth in those years and makes it the precondition of self-summoning. To summon the Persona, the user must rehearse the anticipation of death—Heidegger's *Vorlaufen*, Plato's definition of philosophy as practice for dying (*Phaedo* 64a), Montaigne's "to philosophize is to learn to die" (*Essais* I.20)—and convert it into the resolve to live.

4.2 Nyx, Erebus and the woman who anticipated the death drive

The cosmological antagonists are taken from Hesiod. Nyx, primordial Night, is the mother of Thanatos, Hypnos, Moros and Nemesis (*Theogony* 211–225); in the Orphic theogonies she is supreme and oracular, the power even Zeus consults. Erebus is in the game something new: the accumulated death-wish of humanity, which calls Nyx down to end all life. The game's metaphysics thus distinguishes three relations to death: death *desired* (Erebus), death *denied* (the coffined masses), and death *acknowledged and given* (the protagonist).

Erebus is Freud's death drive collectivized: the conservative tendency of the organism to return to the inorganic, formulated in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920). Yet the genealogy is incomplete without Sabina Spielrein. Admitted to the Burghölzli clinic in Zürich in 1904 as Jung's patient, she became a physician and analyst in her own right. Jung, while treating her and afterward, entered into an intimate relationship with her, a breach of the therapeutic bond whose physical extent historians still dispute, and when the affair threatened his standing he disclaimed responsibility in letters to her mother and to Freud (Carotenuto 1982; Kerr 1993). Her paper "Destruction as the Cause of Coming into Being" (1912) argued, eight years before Freud, that the reproductive drive harbors a destructive component and that becoming requires the dissolution of the prior self. Freud acknowledged her in a single footnote. She later returned to the Soviet Union, where psychoanalysis was suppressed in the 1930s, and in August 1942 she and her two daughters were murdered by German SS units in the massacre at Zmievskaya Balka in Rostov-on-Don. Her papers lay unread in a Geneva basement until 1977. Spielrein's formulation is closer to *P3* than Freud's: in the game, the death-wish is not merely regressive but the shadow side of transformation, and the protagonist's death is a becoming. The thanatology of the series' most philosophically ambitious game therefore descends from a woman's theory, acknowledged in a footnote and otherwise absorbed by men—the first clear instance of the Matilda effect in the series' intellectual lineage (Rossiter 1993).

Strega, the counter-team of artificial Persona-users who worship Nyx as liberation, occupy what Nishitani Keiji called the field of nihility: the standpoint at which all meaning is negated but negation itself has become a new fixation. The protagonist's acceptance of finitude occupies, by contrast, Nishitani's field of emptiness, where things are affirmed in their impermanence (*Religion and Nothingness*, 1961). The Japanese aesthetic of *mono no aware*, the pathos of transience theorized by Motoori Norinaga, governs the game's calendar: the year runs from cherry blossom to cherry blossom, and its last scene is a farewell.

4.3 The lunar masks

The major antagonists of *P3* arrive at the full moon, each an Arcana Shadow. W. B. Yeats's *A Vision* (1925) organized all human types along twenty-eight phases of the moon, each with its Will, Mask, Creative Mind and Body of Fate, and held that the full moon, Phase 15, admits no human incarnation, being a phase of complete beauty in which the self is wholly absorbed in its image. *P3*'s lunar cycle reproduces this structure: at the full moon the human is overtaken by the archetype, and the party must fight the Arcana themselves. The Mask becomes lethal when it is no longer worn by anyone.

4.4 The party: an onomastic reading

Character	Personas	Mythic substrate	What the name carries
Yukari Takeba	Io → Isis	Io, transformed and persecuted after Zeus's desire; Isis, who gathers the scattered body of Osiris (Plutarch)	From victim of others' choices to restorer of the dismembered father; her arc reconstructs her father's corrupted video testimony
Mitsuru Kirijo	Penthesilea → Artemisia	The Amazon queen slain by Achilles, who loves her as she dies; the Carian queen who commanded ships at Salamis	From the woman killed under the male gaze to the commander of whom Xerxes said his men had become women and his women men (Herodotus 8.88)

Character	Personas	Mythic substrate	What the name carries
Fuuka Yamagishi	Lucia → Juno	Saint Lucy, patron of the blind, bearing her eyes; Juno, protector of women	The bullied girl whose power is perception: the medial woman (Chapter 7)
Aigis	Palladion → Athena	The guardian image of Troy; the goddess born from Zeus's head, who in the *Eumenides* votes with the father because no mother bore her	The weapon of a corporate patriarchy, whose subjecthood begins as devotion
Chidori Yoshino	Medea	The foreign witch who kills her children; author of Euripides' protest that she would rather stand three times in battle than bear one child	Inverted: Chidori gives her shortened life to revive Junpei
Shinjiro Aragaki / Akihiko Sanada	Castor / Polydeuces → Caesar	The Dioscuri, one mortal and one immortal	The mortal twin dies; the immortal lives on
Koromaru	Cerberus	The guardian of the threshold of Hades	A dog awakens a Persona: personhood is not species-bound (Haraway 2003)

The table shows the compendium doing what the script cannot: it gives Yukari a mythic arc from Io's victimization to Isis's restorative agency, gives Mitsuru the Herodotean figure of gender inversion, and stores in Chidori the most famous female protest in Greek tragedy. Aigis requires separate treatment. As an anti-Shadow weapon who learns to want, she is Donna Haraway's cyborg, the figure of an identity that owes nothing to organic origin (1985), and Kleist's marionette, whose grace precedes self-consciousness (1810). But as Anne Balsamo (1996) argued of the gendered machine, the gynoid's subjectivity is too easily scripted as service: Aigis's first desire is to remain beside the protagonist. Her name, Athena's shield, binds her to the motherless daughter of the father.

4.5 Orpheus, Death and the gift

The protagonist's first Persona is Orpheus. A decade before the story, during the Moonlight Bridge incident, Aigis sealed Death itself inside him as a child; the self is, from the start, a crypt in the sense of Abraham and Torok (1978), a body that bears an unassimilated death. Death returns as Ryoji Mochizuki, a gentle transfer student who befriends the protagonist and finally offers a choice: kill him and forget everything, living in peace until the world ends, or keep the memory and face Nyx. The choice between blissful ignorance and resolute knowledge is the game's central ethical act, and its "bad ending" makes the stakes explicit.

The protagonist, having gathered the Universe, the totality of his bonds, becomes the Great Seal that prevents Erebus from reaching Nyx. He dies, in the game's final image, on the school roof. Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) supplies the logic. Death is the one thing no one can do in my place, the ground of my irreplaceability and therefore of responsibility; yet one can die *for* another, giving death as a gift without the certainty of return. Mauss's gift economy (1925) is at work: the bonds of the year are gifts that obligate, and the counter-gift is the world's continued life. The protagonist's death is neither denial (Becker 1973) nor desire (Erebus) but donation.

The arrangement has a structure familiar from Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), in which a city's happiness depends on the hidden suffering of one sealed child. The peace of the world after *P3* depends on a youth sealed eternally between humanity's death-wish and the end of all life. *The Answer* is the community's confrontation with its Omelas.

4.6 *The Answer*: Metis and the Orphic inversion

In *The Answer* (*FES*, 2007; remade as *Episode Aigis*, 2024), the survivors are trapped in a repeating final day. Aigis confronts Metis, who claims to be her sister and is revealed as an emanation of Aigis's own psyche, seeking to open a door to retrieve the protagonist. The name is decisive. In Hesiod, Metis, goddess of cunning intelligence, was Zeus's first wife; prophesied to bear a son who would overthrow him, she was swallowed,

and Athena was born from Zeus's head (*Theogony* 886–900). Detienne and Vernant reconstructed *mētis* as a form of practical, oblique intelligence that Greek thought associated with the feminine and the trickster (1974). *The Answer* stages the return of the swallowed mother from inside Athena's avatar: the matricidal archive briefly reverses itself.

The survivors descend into the Abyss of Time, learn the truth of the Seal, and choose not to retrieve him, honoring his choice. Aigis inherits the Wild Card. The Orphic myth is thereby inverted: the male Orpheus has become the irretrievable Eurydice, and women undertake the descent. Elizabeth, the *P3* attendant, completes the inversion in the *Arena* games, abandoning the Velvet Room to seek a way to free him. H.D.'s Eurydice had refused to be an object of retrieval; *P3*'s women refuse to treat the protagonist as one.

The cycle's most radical gesture came in *Portable* (2009), which offered a female protagonist with her own Social Links and a male attendant, Theodore. Her omission from *Reload* (2024), which otherwise remade the game with lavish fidelity, provoked sustained critique. Read onomastically, the omission repeats the swallowing of Metis: the woman of will is incorporated into the franchise's past and excluded from its canonical present.

4.7 The Kirijo inheritance: corporate science and the bodies of children

Behind the cosmology of *P3* stands a corporation. The Dark Hour and Tartarus are not natural phenomena but the residue of an industrial accident. Kouetsu Kirijo, patriarch of the Kirijo Group, directed research into Shadows in pursuit of power over time, and in 1999 an explosion at the company's laboratory scattered the Shadows it had gathered and produced the hidden hour. The company's handling of the disaster is the plot's buried scandal. Eiichiro Takeba, a researcher killed in the blast, was publicly blamed for it. Years later Shuji Ikutsuki, the school-board chairman who advises SEES, doctored Takeba's surviving video message so that a warning against destroying the Arcana Shadows played as an instruction to destroy them; when the deception collapsed, Ikutsuki shot and killed Mitsuru's father, Takeharu Kirijo. Yukari's arc, read in 4.4

through Isis gathering the dismembered Osiris, is precise in a further sense: she reassembles a father's testimony that a corporation's agent had falsified.

The company's experiments fell hardest on children. The members of Strega are survivors of a Kirijo program that subjected orphaned children to experiments meant to induce artificial Personas; most of the subjects died, and the survivors depend on suppressant drugs that shorten their lives. Aigis was built in Kirijo laboratories as an anti-Shadow weapon, and the *Arena* games reveal that the earliest of these gynoids, "sisters" to one another, were made to fight to destruction to generate combat data; Labrys is their survivor. SEES itself enlists Ken Amada, a ten-year-old, into armed combat, and the game never asks whether it should.

Ken's own wound comes from the same apparatus. Two years before the story, during a Kirijo operation, Shinjiro Aragaki lost control of his Persona and killed Ken's mother, and the death was recorded as an accident. Ken joins SEES intending to kill Shinjiro on the anniversary. Shinjiro, who has been taking the life-shortening suppressants and is ready to die at Ken's hand, is instead shot by Takaya while shielding him. The game thereby denies Ken both revenge and forgiveness—the faculty Arendt called the only remedy for the irreversibility of action (*The Human Condition*, §33)—and leaves him carrying an act that no one can now undo. His Persona's name, Nemesis, names the retribution the plot takes from him.

Mitsuru Kirijo inherits all of it. Her Social Link turns on an engagement arranged for the heiress of the group, which she breaks off: the traffic in women (Rubin 1975) refused inside the corporation that also trafficked in children's bodies. After her father's murder she takes on the company and its debt of guilt. The configuration has Japanese precedents that the game does not name but that its premise recalls. The Chisso Corporation's discharge of methylmercury into Minamata Bay poisoned a coastal population for decades, including children poisoned in the womb, while the company and the state delayed acknowledgment; Ishimure Michiko's *Kugai jōdo* (*Paradise in the Sea of Sorrow*, 1969) turned the victims' testimony into literature. Hans Jonas, whose work on Gnosis informs Chapter 2, argued that technological power demands an ethics of

responsibility toward those who will bear its consequences, the unborn included (*Das Prinzip Verantwortung*, 1979). The Kirijo inheritance is that ethics first betrayed and then, in Mitsuru, belatedly assumed.

V



Part Two: Four Anthropologies

Persona 4: The Epistemology of Fog

Persona 4 (2008), *Golden* (2012)

5.1 Inaba and the confessional apparatus

Persona 4 (2008) relocates the series from metropolis to countryside. Inaba is a town of shuttered shopping streets undercut by Junes, a national big-box chain; its youth find it boring; its adults are tired. The critical commonplace comparing it to Lynch and Frost's *Twin Peaks* (1990–91)—a small town, a murdered young woman, a world behind the world—is apt, but the game's medium is television rather than the Red Room. On rainy nights, the Midnight Channel broadcasts its next victim; inside the screen lies a world shaped by the collective unconscious of the town, where each victim's repressed self, the Shadow, stages a spectacle of their secret.

The Midnight Channel is a confessional apparatus. Foucault argued that modern power operates by inciting the subject to speak its sexual truth before an authority who judges, interprets and absolves (*The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1, 1976). In Inaba the authority is an audience. Each Shadow proclaims the victim's secret before witnesses—the friends who have come to rescue them—and liberation requires public avowal. Debord's "spectacle," a social relation among people mediated by images (1967), here takes the form of a town that knows itself only through what its television reveals. And Sedgwick's analysis of the closet as the defining epistemological structure of modern Western culture (1990) clarifies the stakes: the Midnight Channel *outs* people.

5.2 "I am a Shadow, the true self"

Each confrontation follows a fixed liturgy. The Shadow declares itself the victim's true self; the victim, horrified, denies it; denial empowers the Shadow, which becomes a monster; only after battle does the victim acknowledge it, and the Shadow becomes a Persona. The formula combines three theories. It is Jung's integration of the Shadow. It is Freud's melancholia, in which an ungrieved loss is incorporated so that "the shadow of the object fell upon the ego" ("Mourning and Melancholia," 1917). And it is Mary Shelley's Creature, who tells his maker that he was benevolent and good and that misery made him a

fiend (*Frankenstein*, ch. 10): rejection produces the monster, and recognition alone can unmake it.

5.3 The dungeons as gender theory

Yosuke Hanamura, whose father manages the town's Junes, is the first to enter, and his position is economic before it is psychological. Junes stands for the big-box retail that deregulation released on provincial Japan once the Large-Scale Retail Store Law was dismantled between 1998 and 2000, and Inaba's shuttered shopping street blames it. Saki Konishi, daughter of the local liquor store and a part-time worker at Junes, is caught between the two. Yosuke loved her, and in the television world he hears that she found him tiresome; his Shadow accuses him of treating her murder as an escape from provincial boredom. The scene matters for the argument of 5.4. Saki stands at the center of two men's stories, and the game sets Yosuke's grief, which survives the discovery of her indifference, against Adachi's violence, which by his own account followed rejection. Yosuke's Personas, Jiraiya and Susano-o—the outlaw toad-ninja of Edo fiction and the storm god whose rampage drove the sun into hiding—give his restlessness a mythic scale and place him beside Yukiko's Amaterasu as the unruly brother of the sun.

Yukiko Amagi, heiress to a traditional inn, appears in a castle as a princess waiting for a prince to carry her away. The dungeon literalizes what feminist critics of the fairy tale analyzed as the romance script of rescue (Lieberman 1972; Zipes 1986) and what Anita Sarkeesian later catalogued as the damsel in distress. Its resolution is not rescue but self-acknowledgment, and Yukiko later chooses to remain at the inn, a choice the game presents as freedom and that debates over "choice feminism" would treat as ambiguous, given Ueno Chizuko's account of the household system and the ideology of the "good wife, wise mother" (2010). Her Personas speak more clearly. Konohana-sakuya-hime is the blossom bride whose husband's preference for beauty over endurance made human life brief; Amaterasu is the sun goddess whom Hiratsuka Raichō reclaimed in 1911: "In the beginning, woman was truly the sun"—before she became a moon shining by another's light. Yukiko's evolution

from Konohana to Amaterasu enacts Raichō's manifesto: from beauty under a male gaze to self-generated light.

Chie Satonaka's Shadow is a whip-wielding dominatrix enthroned in Yukiko's castle, voicing Chie's resentment of the friend whom she protects in order to feel needed. The Japanese archetype of female jealousy is Lady Rokujō in *The Tale of Genji* (c. 1008), whose living spirit possesses and kills her rival without her conscious knowledge; Noh stages that spirit in the horned *hannya* mask. Rokujō is a Shadow avant la lettre, and Murasaki Shikibu, the woman who wrote her, may claim priority over Jung. The game, however, codes Chie's aggression as sexualized dominance, a choice that reinscribes the gaze it purports to expose. Her Personas, Tomoe Gozen and Suzuka Gongen, are warrior women: Toni Wolff's Amazon (Chapter 7).

Kanji Tatsumi's dungeon is a steam bathhouse; his Shadow is a flamboyant gay caricature. Kanji, a delinquent who sews and knits dolls, fears that his tastes unman him and that girls reject him. Mishima's *Confessions of a Mask* (1949) had told the story of a youth who performs normative masculinity over a homosexual desire he cannot speak; Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) showed how male bonds are policed by the threat of homosexuality; Butler's account of gender melancholia (1997) explained heterosexual masculinity as constituted by an ungrievable loss. *P4* gestures toward all three and then retreats: the resolution frames Kanji's fear as fear of rejection in general, and his friends' jokes keep queerness in comic quarantine. Onomastically, the retreat fails. Kanji's ultimate Persona, Rokuten Maō, is the Demon King of the Sixth Heaven—Māra, sovereign of the highest heaven of the realm of desire. The compendium crowns him lord of the desire the script refuses to name.

Rise Kujikawa, a teen idol on hiatus, is confronted in her dungeon by a Shadow that performs a striptease in her image before an imagined audience, broadcast to the town. The scene literalizes Laura Mulvey's analysis of woman as image and man as bearer of the look (1975) and the commodified girlhood of the idol industry (Galbraith and Karlin 2012). The mythic substrate is again more complex. Rise's Arcana, the Lovers, also houses Ame-no-Uzume, whose exposing dance before the Heavenly

Rock Cave made the gods laugh and returned the sun to the world: in myth, a woman's display is sacred and cosmogonic; in the game, it is shame. Rise's Personas are Himiko, the shaman queen of Yamatai recorded in the Chinese *Wei zhi*, and Kanzeon, the bodhisattva who perceives the cries of the world—a deity that, as Chün-fang Yü has shown (2001), was transformed from the male Avalokiteśvara into the female Guanyin across East Asia. Rise's final Persona is a figure of successful gender transformation.

Naoto Shirogane, a teenage detective who presents as a boy, is the series' most contested figure. Her dungeon is a secret laboratory in which her Shadow proposes bodily modification; the resolution reveals that Naoto wished to be male because the police world would not take a girl seriously, and the game frames acceptance as acceptance of being a woman. Trans and gender-nonconforming readers have read this resolution as foreclosure; others have read Naoto through Jack Halberstam's *Female Masculinity* (1998) as a legitimate formation of masculinity in a female body that the game recuperates into femininity. A third reading emerges from the archive. Susan Stryker's essay "My Words to Victor Frankenstein" (1994) claimed the Creature as a figure of transgender embodiment and rage; Naoto's dungeon is the series' explicitly Frankensteinian space, inside a franchise whose attendants bear the names of Frankenstein's women. And Naoto's ultimate Persona is Yamato-Takeru, the prince of the *Kojiki* who disguised himself as a maiden to accomplish his heroic deed. The narrative ego closes the question of gender; the mythic unconscious keeps it open. Japanese popular culture had long kept it open too, from Tezuka's *Princess Knight* (1953) and Ikeda Riyoko's *The Rose of Versailles* (1972–73) to the Takarazuka Revue's male-role actresses (Robertson 1998) and Yoshimoto Banana's *Kitchen* (1988), whose beloved mother Eriko is a trans woman. Measured against that tradition, *P4*'s resolution is a retreat, not a norm.

One further precedent sharpens the point. Ikuhara Kunihiko's anime *Revolutionary Girl Utena* (1997) had already staged both of *P4*'s gendered scripts as objects of critique: its heroine wants to become a prince rather than be rescued by one, and its "Rose Bride" is passed among student duelists as a prize, the traffic in women (Rubin 1975) rendered as school

ritual. Where *Utena* dismantles the castle and the prince together, *P4* frees Yukiko from the castle and returns Naoto to the princess's side of the line.

Teddie, a Shadow-being in a hollow bear costume, confronts a Shadow that tells him he is empty; his ultimate Persona is Kamui, borrowed from Ainu cosmology. He is the nonhuman who wishes to be human, a gentle Creature, and his borrowed divinity is a quiet sign of the colonial archive that the game's national mythology passes over. **Marie**, added in *Golden* (2012), is revealed as a fragment of Izanami who has lost her memory. She writes poetry that the game treats as comic embarrassment. The only woman in the cycle defined by writing is a fragment of the abject mother, and her writing is a joke: Gilbert and Gubar's "anxiety of authorship" (1979), and Cixous's injunction that woman must write herself (1975), measure the distance. She ends as a television weather forecaster, the voice that announces the fog.

5.4 Three pathologies of masculine recognition

The antagonists form a typology. **Tohru Adachi**, the affable junior detective living at the edge of the protagonist's household, is the killer. He killed Mayumi Yamano, a television announcer, and Saki Konishi, a high-school student, by pushing them into the television world, where they died; by his own account, the killings followed rejection and were sustained by boredom. Kate Manne defines misogyny as the enforcement mechanism of patriarchal order, punishing women who fail to supply feminine-coded goods, and "himpathy" as the excessive sympathy extended to male perpetrators (*Down Girl*, 2017). The inaugural crime of *P4* is misogynist enforcement, and the fandom's long affection for Adachi is himpathy in the wild. His boredom recalls Kierkegaard's claim that boredom is the root of all evil ("Rotation of Crops," *Either/Or*, 1843) and Heidegger's profound boredom (1929–30). His Persona, Magatsu-Izanagi, is a corrupted Izanagi: he is the protagonist's dark double, another urban transplant who received power from the same goddess. **Mitsuo Kubo**, the copycat who murdered the teacher Kinshirō Morooka and then claimed all the killings as his own, has a Shadow rendered as an empty eight-bit game: a self without content seeking recognition through violence (Honneth 1992). **Taro Namatame** threw victims into the

television to "save" them: paternalist rescue that becomes abduction. Entitlement, emptiness and paternalism: three ways in which masculine selves deprived of recognition turn on others. Adachi's violence falls on women and Namatame's on the young; Mitsuo's falls on whoever is at hand, an older man included, which is what emptiness means.

The cycle's sharpest ethical test falls on a child. In December, Namatame abducts Nanako Dojima, the protagonist's first-grade cousin, and throws her into the television world, believing he is saving her. Her mother was killed years earlier by a hit-and-run driver whom her father, the detective Ryotaro Dojima, has never found. Rescued but gravely weakened, Nanako appears to die in hospital, and the Investigation Team confronts Namatame in his room with the means to push him into a television. The player may do it. If so, the game ends there: the true killer is never identified and the fog never lifts. René Girard described the scapegoat mechanism by which a community in crisis restores its unity by killing a single victim (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972; *Le Bouc émissaire*, 1982). Namatame, guilty of abduction but not of murder, is the perfect scapegoat. The game's verdict is Girard's: the lynching would end the crisis falsely, and only restraint lets Nanako recover and the truth about Adachi emerge.

5.5 Izanami and the passion for ignorance

The true ending reveals that the gas-station attendant who shook the protagonist's hand on his first day was Izanami, who distributed power to three men to discover what humanity desires. Her answer is that humanity wants fog: to see only what it wishes, to live in comfortable illusion. The thesis echoes Plato's cave, Nietzsche's account of truth as "a mobile army of metaphors" forgotten as such (1873), Lacan's identification of ignorance as one of the three passions alongside love and hate, and Sloterdijk's cynical reason, in which people know very well what they do and do it anyway (1983). The protagonist, as Izanagi-no-Ōkami, defeats her.

A feminist reading cannot let the victory stand unexamined. *P4* codes truth as masculine vision—Izanagi, the seer, assisted by eyeglasses that cut through fog—and opacity as feminine: Izanami, Marie, the fog itself.

Luce Irigaray argued that Western metaphysics privileges sight in a specular economy that constitutes woman as "nothing to see" (*Speculum of the Other Woman*, 1974); Julia Kristeva described the maternal body as the abject, what must be expelled for the subject to constitute itself (1980). The final battle repeats Izanagi's forbidden look and flight—the very scene Kawai Hayao placed at the origin of Japanese *aware*—as heroic triumph. In Erich Neumann's Jungian monomyth, the ego is born by slaying the Terrible Mother (*The Origins and History of Consciousness*, 1949). *P4* performs that matricide on the goddess for whom the franchise is named.

5.6 The right to opacity

A counter-reading is available within the game's own evidence. Édouard Glissant defended a *droit à l'opacité*, a right to opacity against the Western demand that the other be made transparent in order to be understood, a demand he identified with colonial comprehension (*Poetics of Relation*, 1990). Byung-Chul Han argued that a society of transparency is a society of control (2012). Arendt warned that the passion for unmasking destroys the protective persona. Kanji and Naoto are not liberated by the Midnight Channel; they are exposed by it, and their friends' compassion does not undo the violence of the broadcast. The fog that the game defeats is also the shelter in which an unfinished self might have completed its transformation in private. Chapter 10 will name that shelter: the chrysalis.

VI



Part Two: Four Anthropologies

Persona 5 and *Royal*: The Politics of the Heart

Persona 5 (2016), *Royal* (2019)

6.1 A trickster in a penal cosmos

Persona 5 (2016) is the series' most explicitly political work, and its politics begin in the juridical. The protagonist arrives in Tokyo on probation. He had intervened when a drunken man was forcing a woman into his car; the man stumbled, injured himself, and had the boy charged with assault, and the woman was pressured into testifying against her rescuer. The man was Masayoshi Shido, who becomes the game's final human antagonist. The frame narrative is the protagonist's interrogation by the prosecutor Sae Niijima, so that the entire game is testimony. The Velvet Room has become a prison: the protagonist wakes in a cell, guarded by twin wardens, told that he is undergoing "rehabilitation." Its operations are penal. Personas are fused by guillotine, sacrificed on the gallows, converted into equipment in the electric chair, trained in solitary confinement. Foucault's carceral archipelago and its docile bodies (*Discipline and Punish*, 1975) and Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995), the life included in the law only by its exclusion, describe the probationer's condition with precision.

The protagonist's codename is Joker; the game calls him the Trickster. Jung's essay on the trickster (1954), published in Paul Radin's study of Winnebago myth with a commentary by Karl Kerényi, described the figure as a collective Shadow, an archaic boundary-crosser whose disorder precedes and renews order; Lewis Hyde made the trickster the agent by whom cultures remake their categories (1998). The protagonist's companion Morgana, a cat-shaped being made from humanity's residual hope, comes in time to bear Mercurius, the subject of Jung's essay on the alchemical trickster-spirit who unites opposites ("The Spirit Mercurius," 1948).

6.2 Tearing the mask

Awakening in *P5* is violent: a mask materializes on the face of the awakening user and must be torn away, bloodily, whereupon the Persona appears. The paradox is exact. The Persona emerges when the mask is ripped off, and yet the Persona is itself a masked outlaw. Levinas located ethics in the face, whose nudity and destitution command before any

representation (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961). The bleeding face is the Levinasian moment, in which the subject ceases to hide and stands exposed before injustice; the Persona that follows is the Arendtian moment, in which exposure is converted into action and requires a protective mask in order to act. The codenames—Skull, Panther, Fox, Queen, Oracle, Noir, Crow, Violet—are Kierkegaardian pseudonyms: indirect identities through which truths too dangerous for the proper name can be spoken.

6.3 The Palaces as cognitive architecture

A Palace is the distorted cognition of a powerful adult rendered as space: in Yogācāra terms, *parikalpita* built over *paratantra* (Chapter 1).

Ruler	Palace	Cognition	Theoretical key
Suguru Kamoshida, coach	Castle	The school as his kingdom; students as slaves and sexual property	Manne 2017; Berger 1972; Nussbaum 1995
Ichiryusai Madarame, painter	Museum	Pupils as property; art as commodity	Benjamin 1935; Adorno and Horkheimer 1944; Goya's *Saturn*
Junya Kaneshiro, extortionist	Bank	The city as a cash machine; youth as collateral	Graeber 2011; Lazzarato 2011
Futaba Sakura (herself)	Pyramid	Her guilt as a tomb	Saitō 1998; Freud 1917
Kunikazu Okumura, executive	Spaceport	Workers as robots	Marx 1844; Čapek 1920
Sae Niijima, prosecutor	Casino	Justice as a rigged game one must win	Kafka 1925; institutional sexism
Masayoshi Shido, politician	Cruise ship	The nation as a ship only he can steer	Plato, *Republic* VI; Schmitt 1922; Maruyama 1946
The public	Mementos (subway)	The collective Palace of a society that wishes to be ruled	Fromm 1941; La Boétie c. 1548

Ruler	Palace	Cognition	Theoretical key
Takuto Maruki, counselor (*Royal*)	Research facility	Reality as therapy	Nozick 1974; Rogers 1961

6.4 The fathers fall: Kamoshida, Madarame, Kaneshiro

Kamoshida, an Olympic medalist whose physical abuse of his volleyball team the principal conceals to protect the school's reputation, sexually harasses Ann Takamaki. When she refuses him, he sexually assaults her closest friend, Shiho Suzui—the game establishes the assault without depicting it—and Shiho attempts suicide at school. He punishes one girl's refusal through another girl's body: misogyny as enforcement, in Manne's sense, redirected onto a substitute. In his Palace, Ann encounters her cognitive double: Kamoshida's fantasy-image of her as a compliant slave. John Berger's formula—men act and women appear; women watch themselves being looked at (*Ways of Seeing*, 1972)—becomes literal, since Ann watches the image of herself as Kamoshida looks at it. Her awakening is the refusal of that image. Her Personas trace a feminist arc. Carmen, of Mérimée and Bizet, is the woman who will not be possessed and is killed for it; Hecate is the triple goddess of crossroads and witchcraft; Célestine, in *Royal*, is overdetermined, recalling both Octave Mirbeau's chambermaid, who exposes the sexual hypocrisy of the households she serves (1900), and Fernando de Rojas's Celestina, the go-between of the sexual economy (1499). Kamoshida's castle is Bluebeard's (Perrault, 1697), and Angela Carter's revision (1979), in which the heroine's mother rides to the rescue, is the feminist template the game half follows: Ann is rescued by her own fury.

Kamoshida's violence is also a weapon of class. Ryuji Sakamoto, raised by a single mother after an abusive father left, was the track team's star until Kamoshida provoked him, broke his leg and disbanded the team, then branded him a violent delinquent; the school accepted the coach's account. Ryuji's Personas trace the rebel's arc: Captain Kidd, the privateer whose noble backers abandoned him to the gallows; Seiten Taisei, the Monkey King of *Journey to the West*, who rebelled against Heaven and was imprisoned beneath a mountain by the Buddha; and, in *Royal*, William,

the man behind the pirate's title. The boy whom an institution marked as violent is the one in whom the game first locates righteous anger.

Madarame plagiarizes his pupils and sells copies of a painting whose original he keeps, a masterpiece by Yusuke Kitagawa's mother, whom he let die. Benjamin's aura (1935) and the culture industry (1944) frame the commodity; Goya's *Saturn Devouring His Son* frames the father who consumes his sons' work. Junya Kaneshiro, a Shibuya crime boss, traps students into carrying drugs for his gang and then blackmails them; when Makoto investigates, he photographs her and her friends and demands three million yen. Makoto Niijima, the model student, awakens to Johanna, the motorcycle-Persona named for Pope Joan, the legendary woman who rose to the papacy disguised as a man and was exposed in childbirth; the legend served for centuries to police female ambition. Makoto's *Royal* Persona, Agnes, bears one of the names the legend gave Joan. The series reclaims the woman whose exposure was meant as warning.

6.5 The matricide at the origin

The conspiracy that drives the plot rests on a crime against a woman. Wakaba Isshiki, researcher of "cognitive psience," developed the knowledge that makes the Metaverse operable; Shido's conspiracy seized her research, and Goro Akechi, Shido's unacknowledged son, killed her on its orders by inducing a mental shutdown that sent her into the path of a car. The conspirators staged the death as suicide and read a forged suicide note, blaming the child, aloud in front of Futaba. Futaba withdraws into *hikikomori* isolation and then does something unprecedented in the series: she asks the Thieves to steal her own heart, consenting to her own transformation. Her Palace is a pyramid, a tomb built of guilt. Luce Irigaray argued that Western culture rests not on Freud's primal patricide but on an earlier, unacknowledged matricide, the murder of Clytemnestra ("Le corps-à-corps avec la mère," 1981). The rhyme is exact: Orestes kills his mother at the command of Apollo, the paternal god; Akechi kills the mother of the Metaverse in the service of his own father. *P5* stages a long sequence of symbolic patricides—every Palace ruler is a father or surrogate father—upon a founding matricide

that the plot itself narrates. Futaba's Personas move from the *Necronomicon*, the forbidden book, to Prometheus, the thief of fire, to Al Azif, the book's true name: from interdicted knowledge to stolen knowledge to knowledge called by its own name. The daughter recovers the mother's science.

6.6 Labor, exchange, judgment

Okumura's Palace imagines workers as robots, Marx's alienated labor rendered as Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), whose word *robot* derives from the Czech for forced labor; its referent is Japan's "black companies" and death from overwork. Okumura has arranged his daughter Haru's engagement to an abusive heir, a transaction Gayle Rubin analyzed as the "traffic in women," in which kinship systems constitute women as gifts exchanged between men (1975). Haru's Personas are Milady, the woman whom Dumas's musketeers try and execute as a brotherhood, and Astarte, the Canaanite goddess demonized by Hebrew monotheism. At the press conference where he begins his public confession, her father collapses and dies: Akechi, acting for Shido, has killed his Shadow in the Metaverse so that the death will be blamed on the Phantom Thieves. The change of heart has become an alibi for murder, and the game knows it.

Sae's Palace is a casino. A woman prosecutor in a masculine institution, she has learned that justice is a game she must win to survive. Her Arcanum is Judgement, and the frame narrative places the entire game before her as evidence. Akechi, the "Detective Prince," is Shido's unacknowledged son, the assassin behind the mental shutdowns; his twin Personas, Robin Hood (the just outlaw of his public mask) and Loki (the destroyer beneath), give form to the Hegelian struggle for recognition (*Phenomenology of Spirit*, 1807) and to Rousseau's *amour-propre*. He is the protagonist's Shadow: a Wild Card born of misrecognition.

6.7 Shido and the ship of state

Shido's Palace is a cruise ship on which only he can steer the nation. Plato's allegory of the ship of state (*Republic* VI, 488a–489a) mocked the

sailors who seize the helm without knowledge of navigation; Shido inverts it, casting himself as the sole true navigator and the public as passengers. His power operates through mental shutdowns, decisions on the exception in Carl Schmitt's sense (1922), and through what Maruyama Masao called the "system of irresponsibility" of prewar Japan, in which no one decides and everyone obeys (1946). To defeat him the protagonist surrenders himself to testify, accepting detention: justice is obtained by renouncing the trickster's immunity.

6.8 The calling card and the gnostic temptation

The Phantom Thieves' instrument is the calling card. In the Palace, the Treasure—the core of a distorted desire—materializes only after the card has been delivered and the target becomes conscious of the threat. The card is a performative in J. L. Austin's sense (1962): its utterance brings about the state it names. It is also a *counter-interpellation*. Althusser described ideology as the hail that recruits individuals as subjects (1970); the calling card hails the powerful and recruits them as subjects of their own guilt. The result is the change of heart: the target confesses publicly, often in tears.

The method is morally hazardous, and the game stages the hazard. A change of heart is a forced confession (Foucault); it acts directly on souls by an elect possessing hidden knowledge (Voegelin); it is the passion for unmasking that Arendt traced to Robespierre. *P5* registers each danger: Okumura's death, the Phan-Site's approval meter that makes the Thieves dependent on public opinion, the public's abrupt turn against them, Akechi's use of the same powers for murder. Gustave Le Bon's crowd (1895) is everywhere. The game's mature position is not that changes of heart are good, but that the Thieves must learn what kind of power they wield.

6.9 Voluntary servitude and the God of Control

The final antagonist reframes the political question. Yaldabaoth, the God of Control, exists because the public wished to be ruled: the Holy Grail is the collective desire to be relieved of the burden of choice. The thesis

condenses a lineage. Étienne de La Boétie asked why the many obey the one and answered that servitude is voluntary: "resolve to serve no more, and you are at once free" (*Discours de la servitude volontaire*, c. 1548). Spinoza asked why people fight for their servitude as if for their salvation (*Theological-Political Treatise*, 1670), a question that Wilhelm Reich and then Deleuze and Guattari made central to the analysis of fascism. Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor argued that humanity would trade freedom for bread, miracle and authority (1880). Erich Fromm diagnosed the modern flight into authoritarianism and automaton conformity (*Escape from Freedom*, 1941). Kant had defined enlightenment as the exit from self-incurred immaturity, sustained by laziness and cowardice and by the "guardians" who kindly take over the supervision of others ("What Is Enlightenment?," 1784). Yaldabaoth is Kant's guardian elevated to godhead.

The resolution is Arendtian. Arendt distinguished power, which springs up between people when they act in concert, from violence, which is its opposite and appears where power is lost (*On Violence*, 1970). In the final battle, the public's renewed belief in the Thieves gives Joker the power to summon Satanael and defeat the God of Control: plural power against sovereign violence. Lavenza, split by the Demiurge into the wardens Caroline and Justine, is made whole, and the true Igor returns.

6.10 *Royal*: the therapist as final enemy

Royal (2019) adds a final antagonist more troubling than any god: Takuto Maruki, the school counselor, who has acquired the power to rewrite reality so that everyone's wounds are healed. In his world Ryuji's leg is whole, Futaba's mother lives, Akechi is alive, and Sumire Yoshizawa believes herself to be her dead sister Kasumi. Maruki's founding act was an act of love: he erased the trauma of his girlfriend Rumi, and with it her memory of him.

Maruki's ideology is humanistic psychology perverted. Abraham Maslow placed self-actualization at the summit of human motivation (1943); Carl Rogers held that suffering arises from incongruence between self-concept and experience and that congruence is reached through unconditional positive regard (1951, 1961). Maruki achieves congruence

by altering experience—reality itself—rather than the self, and calls the result actualization. His offer is Robert Nozick's experience machine (1974), which most people refuse because they want to do things and to be certain kinds of people, not merely to have experiences; it is Huxley's brave new world; it is Nietzsche's last man, who has invented happiness and blinks (*Zarathustra*, Prologue §5). His Personas, Azathoth and Adam Kadmon, the blind god at the center of chaos and the primordial human of Lurianic Kabbalah, name the ambition precisely: to make chaos into a new Adam.

Sumire's arc carries the game's argument into the clinic. Her belief that she is Kasumi is melancholic incorporation in Abraham and Torok's sense—the lost object swallowed whole rather than mourned—and an instance of the "replacement child" syndrome described in the clinical literature (Cain and Cain 1964). Her Personas tell the story: Cendrillon, Cinderella, whose identity is proved by a shoe, and in the Grimms' version (1812) the stepsisters mutilate their own feet to fit it; Vanadis, a name of Freyja, who weeps tears of red gold for her lost husband; and Ella, the girl's own name. Her recovery is the recovery of a proper name.

The protagonist rejects Maruki's world, and Akechi, alive only within it, insists that he do so. The *Royal* third-tier Personas complete the argument: Raoul behind Arsène Lupin, William behind Captain Kidd, Diego de la Vega behind Zorro, Al Azif behind the *Necronomicon*, Agnes behind Pope Joan, Hereward behind Robin Hood, Ella behind Cinderella. In most cases the final metamorphosis of the mask is not a naked face but a proper name: the singular "who" that Arendt said action discloses and that Adriana Cavarero called the narratable self (1997). *Royal* thus ends the series' most political cycle with a tragic humanism: reality is painful, it is chosen, and the self that chooses it has a name.

VII



Part Three: Critical Interventions

The Matricidal Archive: Gender, the Medial Woman, and the Onomastic Unconscious

7.1 Two theories of matricide

The series' imaginal humanism rests on a structure it never names. Erich Neumann's *Origins and History of Consciousness* (1949), the most systematic Jungian account of the birth of the ego, narrates consciousness as a heroic myth in which the ego emerges from the uroboric Great Mother by slaying her in dragon form before confronting the Father; the Great Mother, in her terrible aspect, is what devours (*The Great Mother*, 1955). Irigaray, from the opposite pole, argued that the matricide at the origin of Western culture is unsymbolized: the mother is killed and the killing forgotten, so that the culture can imagine itself born of fathers alone. Barbara Creed's account of horror's "monstrous-feminine" (1993) showed how the archaic mother returns, in popular genres, as the figure of engulfment and dissolution.

Read together, these theories describe the series' cosmology. Its apocalypses are mothers: Pandora, born of Maki's despair in *P1*; Nyx, mother of Death, in *P3*; Izanami, the primordial mother and the goddess who names the franchise, in *P4*. Its systems run on appropriated feminine interiority: Maki's imagination powers the DEVA System, Wakaba Isshiki's science founds the Metaverse conspiracy. The feminine is *archē* and *eschaton*—origin and end—but almost never the subject who moves between them. This is the matricidal archive: an archive in the double sense of Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995), at once a storehouse and a principle of commencement and command, whose commencement is a matricide and whose command is that the matricide be repeated.

7.2 The Matilda effect in the series' genealogy

Margaret Rossiter named the "Matilda effect" (1993) after the suffragist Matilda Joslyn Gage, whose *Woman as Inventor* (1870) documented the systematic attribution of women's contributions to men. The series' intellectual genealogy displays the effect with unusual density. Its thanatology descends from Sabina Spielrein: the patient with whom Jung broke the therapeutic boundary, the theorist acknowledged in Freud's footnote, the analyst murdered in the Holocaust, whose papers surfaced only in 1977—an archive lost in the most literal sense. Its archetypal

psychology owes more than is credited to Toni Wolff, first Jung's patient, then his collaborator and, for nearly four decades, his lover in an arrangement his wife came to tolerate, whose own typology was published only in 1951; and to Emma Jung, whose *Animus and Anima* (1957) refined the doctrine that bears her husband's name. Both women worked inside a household in which Jung was husband to one and lover to the other, and both are remembered chiefly in relation to him. Its tarot was painted by Pamela Colman Smith and Frieda Harris. Its Velvet Room is staffed by the women of a novel written by the daughter of Mary Wollstonecraft. Inside the fiction the same pattern recurs: Maki's wishes are a man's machine; Wakaba's research is Shido's weapon; Metis is swallowed so that Athena may be born; Sophia, divine Wisdom, is erased from *P5*'s Gnostic cosmology. The fiction reenacts the conditions of its own making. That symmetry is the strongest evidence that the archive is structural rather than incidental.

7.3 The medial woman and the navigator

Toni Wolff's "Structural Forms of the Feminine Psyche" (1951) distinguished four types: the Mother, oriented to care; the Hetaira, the individual companion; the Amazon, independent and achieving; and the Medial woman, receptive to the collective unconscious and able to mediate its contents to others, at the risk of being overwhelmed by them. The fourth type describes, with almost diagnostic precision, the series' navigators: the party members who do not fight but perceive, scan, analyze and speak.

Navigator	Game	Personas	Wolff type	Note
Mitsuru Kirijo	*P3* (provisional)	Penthesilea → Artemisia	Amazon pressed into mediation	Leaves the role for combat once Fuuka arrives
Fuuka Yamagishi	*P3*	Lucia → Juno	Medial	Saint Lucy bears her eyes; perception as sole power
Teddie	*P4* (provisional)	Kintoki-Dōji → Kamui	(nonhuman)	A Shadow-being in an empty costume

Navigator	Game	Personas	Wolff type	Note
Rise Kujikawa	*P4*	Himiko → Kanzeon	Medial	Shaman queen; the bodhisattva who hears the world's cries
Morgana	*P5* (provisional)	Zorro → Mercurius → Diego	(nonhuman)	A cat made of humanity's hope
Futaba Sakura	*P5*	Necronomicon → Prometheus → Al Azif	Medial becoming agent	Hacker; the fire-thief acts on the world

The role is assigned exclusively to women and nonhumans: the position outside phallic agency is shared by girls, a bear and a cat. Its labor is what Arlie Hochschild called emotional labor (*The Managed Heart*, 1983)—reassurance, warning, encouragement—and informational labor, rendered in voice rather than action. Wolff's typology itself has been criticized for defining feminine forms by their relation to men (Wehr 1987). The series' navigators nonetheless show a historical development: from Fuuka's pure perception, through Rise's sovereign hearing, to Futaba's Promethean hacking, the medial woman acquires an agency that acts upon the world. The trajectory is real; it remains incomplete so long as the mainline protagonist is male and combat is led by him.

7.4 Lavenza and the Kleinian prison

Melanie Klein described the infant's earliest relation to the mother as split into good and bad part-objects (the paranoid-schizoid position), and its maturation as the integration of those parts into a whole object toward whom concern and reparation become possible (the depressive position) ("Notes on Some Schizoid Mechanisms," 1946). *P5*'s attendants enact this sequence. The Demiurge has split a single attendant into the twin wardens Caroline and Justine, one harsh and aggressive, the other cold and judicial. Their Frankenstein names deepen the scheme: Caroline is the mother, Justine the scapegoated servant executed for another's crime. Mother and victim, split and set to guard a prisoner, are reunited as

Lavenza only when the protagonist has grown capable of holding ambivalence. The prison of *P5* is the paranoid-schizoid position institutionalized; liberation is its depressive integration.

7.5 The onomastic unconscious

The compendium of Personas is the series' literal collective unconscious, a database of mythic potentials (Azuma 2001) and a polytheistic psyche (Hillman 1975). Its names are not chosen by the scripts' moral logic; they are chosen by designers drawing on world mythology. They therefore behave like parapraxes: they say what the narrative did not mean to say.

Persona	Bearer	Mythic content	What the script disavows
Yamato-Takeru	Naoto	Hero who crossed gender to accomplish his deed	Gender crossing as heroic rather than pathological
Kanzeon	Rise	Bodhisattva transformed from male to female across Asia	Successful gender transformation
Rokuten Maō	Kanji	Sovereign of the heaven of desire	The desire the script refuses to name
Metis	Aigis's Shadow	Swallowed mother of Athena	The return of incorporated feminine intelligence
Isis	Yukari	Restorer of the dismembered god	Female restorative agency
Amaterasu	Yukiko	Self-luminous sun goddess, reclaimed by Raichō	Woman as source rather than reflection
Astarte	Haru	Goddess demonized by monotheism	The goddess behind the exchanged daughter
Johanna / Agnes	Makoto	The woman pope exposed	Female ambition reclaimed from warning
Medea	Chidori	Euripides' female protest	The cost of motherhood and exile
Ariadne → Asterius	Labrys (*Arena*)	The abandoned princess; the Minotaur, whose loneliness Borges imagined (1947)	The double axe, adopted as a lesbian-feminist emblem in the 1970s

The compendium is the series' Shadow in its own technical sense: what the conscious narrative refuses and what, once acknowledged, becomes power.

7.6 Queerness present and contained

Queer content is persistent across the series and persistently contained. *P2* permits an affective choice of Jun Kurosu; *P4* broadcasts Kanji's and Naoto's closets and resolves both toward normativity; *P5* includes a scene in which two predatory gay men harass Ryuji, revised in the Western release of *Royal* after criticism, alongside the warmer figure of the Shinjuku bar owner Lala Escargot. Bonnie Ruberg argues that video games have always been queer, in their structures of failure, desire and alternative temporality (2019). The series confirms the thesis in its structures—the Wild Card's polymorphous multiplicity, the intensity of same-sex bonds in the Social Links—while its scripts repeatedly withdraw what its structures permit.

7.7 The split gaze

The series' romance mechanics inherit the dating simulation, above all Konami's *Tokimeki Memorial* (1994): seasonal events, gift economies, jealousy penalties in *P3*, a Valentine's confrontation in *P5* for the player who dates several companions. *P5* lets its protagonist, a second-year high-school student, enter romantic relationships with two adults: his homeroom teacher, Sadayo Kawakami, and a physician, Tae Takemi. A teacher's romance with a student in her charge is the same structure of authority over a minor that the game condemns in Kamoshida; when the adult is a woman and the student a boy, the game offers it as a reward. The heroine's route in *P3 Portable* likewise lets her Social Link with Ken Amada, a ten-year-old, take a romance-coded turn. The pattern is consistent: the series reads an asymmetry of age and power as predation when the older party is a man and presents it as romance when the older party is female. Beach episodes, swimsuit contests and *P4*'s cross-dressing pageant, which stages drag as humiliation in the sense Butler distinguished from subversive drag (*Bodies That Matter*, 1993), return the

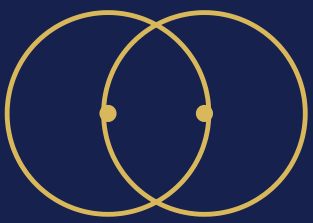
female body to the position Mulvey described. The result may be called a *split gaze*: the series critiques the male gaze diegetically, in Kamoshida's Palace and Rise's dungeon, while reproducing it extradiegetically, in camera, costume and comic register. The critique and the complicity are not alternatives; they are the two faces of a single mask.

The series' most direct treatment of beauty as currency is a Social Link rather than a dungeon. Ai Ebihara, a *P4* classmate bullied in middle school over her appearance, has remade herself into the school's most fashionable girl and measures her worth by the attention of boys, whom she uses as she expects to be used. Naomi Wolf described beauty as a currency system that disciplines women (*The Beauty Myth*, 1990), and Susan Bordo read the disciplined female body as a cultural text (*Unbearable Weight*, 1993). Ai's arc, which moves from manipulation to the risk of being liked for herself, is the split gaze turned inward: a girl who has learned to see herself only as boys see her.

7.8 The women of will at the margin

Kawai's "woman of will" recurs across the corpus: Gerda in *Revelations*' Snow Queen scenario; Maya Amano in *Eternal Punishment*; Elizabeth in the *Arena* games; Aigis in *The Answer*; the heroine of *Portable*; Futaba, who consents to her own transformation; Ann, who refuses her image; Sumire, who reclaims her name. Their distribution is the decisive fact. They appear in optional scenarios, sequels, expansions, portable editions, spin-offs and epilogues—the margins of the canon. The center remains a silent male Wild Card. The women of will occupy what Chapter 10 will call the pupal margin: the casing of the canon, where its transformations actually occur.

VIII



Part Three: Critical Interventions

The Instrumental Bond: Social Links Between Buber, Weil, and the Gift

8.1 The economy of intimacy

From *P3* onward, the Social Link (renamed Confidant in *P5*) is the series' signature mechanic. Each relationship is assigned an Arcanum and advances through ten ranks; each rank yields a material return—experience bonuses when fusing Personas of that Arcanum (*P3*, *P4*), or practical abilities in combat and daily life (*P5*). Access is gated by social statistics (in *P5*: Knowledge, Guts, Proficiency, Kindness, Charm), and every relationship competes for scarce days on a calendar that cannot be replayed within a single cycle.

The objection writes itself. The mechanic appears to institutionalize what Horkheimer called instrumental reason (*Eclipse of Reason*, 1947): a rationality of means indifferent to ends. It invites the player to violate Kant's formula of humanity, which forbids treating persons merely as means (*Groundwork*, 1785, AA 4:429). In Martin Buber's terms (*I and Thou*, 1923), it converts every potential I–Thou encounter into an I–It transaction, in which the other is experienced and used rather than met. The player who follows a guide to maximize ranks, who befriends a classmate for a fusion bonus, enacts precisely the dissonance between narrative and procedure that Clint Hocking named ludonarrative (2007). The narrative says that bonds are sacred; the procedure says that they pay.

8.2 Friendship of utility and the other self

Aristotle distinguished friendships of utility, of pleasure and of virtue, and observed that friendships of utility dissolve when the utility ends, whereas friendships of virtue love the friend for who the friend is (*Nicomachean Ethics* VIII.3). He also defined the virtuous friend as "another self" (*allos autos*, IX.4, 1166a31–32). The Persona incantation "I am thou, thou art I" is an Aristotelian formula rendered as liturgy. The Social Links are designed to begin as friendships of utility and to become friendships of virtue; the game's reward structure, which continues to pay throughout, lags behind its narrative, which tells of utility outgrown.

Montaigne supplied the most famous account of a friendship that exceeds every reason: asked why he loved Étienne de La Boétie, he could

only answer, "because it was he, because it was I" (*Essais* I.28). The same La Boétie wrote the *Discourse on Voluntary Servitude*, the classic analysis of why the many submit to the one. In sixteenth-century Bordeaux, therefore, a single friendship joined the paradigmatic text of perfect friendship to the paradigmatic text of the refusal of servitude. These are the two pillars of *P5*—bonds and rebellion—and the Montaigne–La Boétie hinge shows that their conjunction is not a game designer's convenience but a humanist inheritance.

8.3 Recognition, gift, narration

Axel Honneth reconstructed the Hegelian struggle for recognition as three spheres—love, rights and solidarity—whose denial produces three forms of disrespect: physical violation, exclusion from rights, and denigration of a way of life (*The Struggle for Recognition*, 1992). The Confidants of *P5* traverse all three. Some offer love and intimate trust; others are struggles for rights and legal standing (a doctor framed by her superior, a journalist whose story is suppressed, a prosecutor reckoning with justice); others concern social esteem (a disgraced politician who speaks to an empty square, a shogi prodigy exploited by her mother, a bullied boy who runs a fan website). The mechanic is a ludic institution of recognition.

It is also a gift economy. Mauss showed that the gift obligates a return and that its circulation binds a society together (*Essai sur le don*, 1925). Each rank is a gift of time that obligates; each ability is a counter-gift. Gilbert Simondon's concept of the transindividual (1958) explains why the exchange transforms both parties: psychic and collective individuation are co-constitutive, so that the protagonist does not acquire Arcana from others but individuates with them. Adriana Cavarero adds the narrative dimension. The self, she argues, desires its story to be told by another, since one's life-story is visible only to others (*Relating Narratives*, 1997). Each Confidant asks to be seen and narrated, and the protagonist becomes the bearer of a dozen stories. The Social Link is reciprocal biography.

8.4 Three women's economies: Kawakami, Hifumi, Ohya

Three Confidants of *P5* compose, together, a sociology of what the economy extracts from women. Sadayo Kawakami, the protagonist's homeroom teacher, blames herself for the death of a former student. His guardians exploit that guilt to extort money from her, and she pays them by working nights for a "maid" housekeeping service whose marketing trades on sexual innuendo, where the protagonist becomes her client; the arc ends when the Thieves change the extortionists' hearts. Nietzsche observed that the German *Schuld* means both guilt and debt, and derived the moral concept from the material one (*Zur Genealogie der Moral*, 1887, II §4). Kawakami's story runs the derivation in reverse, converting a teacher's guilt into a cash debt. Her two jobs are one job: the emotional labor of the classroom by day (Hochschild 1983) and the commodified domesticity of the maid economy by night (Galbraith 2011), a "second shift" in Hochschild's later sense (1989) and Nancy Fraser's crisis of care made personal (2016). The game plays the night job as comedy, which is the split gaze of Chapter 7 again.

Hifumi Togo is a teenage shogi player whom her mother markets on television as a beautiful prodigy, and whose matches, she discovers, her mother has been fixing behind her back. Deniz Kandiyoti called the strategies by which women secure advantage within patriarchal constraints "bargaining with patriarchy" (1988); Hifumi's mother has made that bargain on her daughter's behalf, selling a girl's intellect as a girl's image. Hifumi's refusal—honest play, and honest defeats, over a rigged career—is recognition in Honneth's strict sense, which cannot be counterfeited.

Ichiko Ohya is a tabloid journalist investigating the disappearance of a colleague and friend who vanished while pursuing the conspiracy; her editors have moved her off the story, and she drinks at Lala Escargot's bar in Shinjuku. Japan's press-club system, which binds reporters to official sources, has long been analyzed as a cartel that disciplines what can be reported (Freeman 2000). Ohya completes an arc the series began with Maya Amano: the woman journalist whose truth-telling the institution suppresses. In all three cases the protagonist again repairs, and that is where the critique of the next section begins.

8.5 The hero as caregiver, and Maruki as the mechanic's Shadow

The ethics of care—Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982), Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984), Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993), Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999), Virginia Held's *The Ethics of Care* (2006)—provides the most precise account of what the protagonist does between battles. He listens, shows up, remembers, attends. In a genre whose heroes are defined by force, the series defines its hero substantially by care work, a quiet feminization of heroism that is among its most significant achievements.

Yet the protagonist also fixes. Every Confidant's crisis is resolved through him; every arc ends with the other's problem solved. *Royal* turns this structure into an antagonist. Takuto Maruki, the counselor who resolves everyone's suffering by rewriting it, is the Confidant system carried to its conclusion: care as unilateral repair, without the other's struggle and finally without the other's consent. The protagonist's rejection of Maruki is therefore the game's self-critique of its own central mechanic. Tronto's distinction between caring *for* and caring *with* (*Caring Democracy*, 2013)—care as a shared democratic practice rather than a benevolent service—names the passage *Royal* demands: from the hero who repairs to the companion who struggles alongside.

8.6 The school of attention

Simone Weil's essay "Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God" (1942) argued that school exercises, even failed geometry problems, matter because they train attention, and that attention is the substance of love of neighbor: the capacity to ask the afflicted, *Quel est ton tourment?*—"What are you going through?" In a letter of the same year she called attention the rarest and purest form of generosity. The *Persona* calendar is a Weilian school. Its days are divided between classes and examinations, which the player must pass, and the after-school hours in which attention is spent on others. The game's unacknowledged argument is Weil's: the discipline of the classroom and the discipline of friendship are one discipline.

Bernard Stiegler warned that the culture industries capture and destroy the attention of the young, and called for a politics of "taking care of youth" (2008); every technology, he argued after Plato and Derrida, is a *pharmakon*, at once poison and remedy. The *Persona* games are such a pharmakon: commercial products that capture dozens of hours of a young player's attention, and pedagogies that teach its right use.

8.7 The mask of utility

The dissonance can now be read dialectically. Wilde's paradox applies to the bond itself: give a player a mask of utility, and the player may learn to care. The instrumental motive is the larva of the relation, the form in which it first appears; the game is a pedagogy in which I–It serves as propaedeutic to I–Thou. The pedagogy succeeds only if the reward becomes superfluous, and the series marks that moment. In *P3*, the bonds become the Universe, not a bonus but the totality that allows the protagonist to give his life. In *P5*, the Confidants return in the final act not as abilities but as solidarity, campaigning for the protagonist's release from detention. The bond is consummated when it no longer pays.

IX



Part Three: Critical Interventions

Ludic Anthropodicy: The Wager, the Demiurge, and the Player as Advocate

9.1 The wager as structure

The series is organized as a sequence of bets about the human. The pattern descends from the Book of Job, in which *ha-satan*, the Adversary or prosecutor of the heavenly court, wagers that Job's righteousness will not survive suffering; from Goethe's "Prologue in Heaven," in which the Lord permits Mephistopheles to tempt Faust and pronounces that man errs as long as he strives (*Es irrt der Mensch, solang er strebt*); and, philosophically, from Pascal's wager, a bet made under irreducible uncertainty with infinite stakes (*Pensées*, 1670). In *P2*, Philemon and Nyarlathotep wager on whether humanity will overcome its weakness. In *P4*, Izanami conducts an experiment, distributing power to three men to learn what humanity wants. In *P5*, the false Igor, Yaldabaoth, sets the Trickster a game whose outcome will decide the fate of the world. In *Royal*, Maruki makes an offer whose acceptance would settle the question forever. Even *P3*, without a personified gambler, is constructed as a test: whether humanity, confronted with its death-wish, can answer it.

9.2 From theodicy to anthropodicy

Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) undertook to justify God in the face of evil by showing this world to be the best possible. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) answered with ridicule and a practical counsel: "we must cultivate our garden." Kant, in "On the Miscarriage of All Philosophical Trials in Theodicy" (1791), concluded that every doctrinal theodicy fails, and that only an "authentic" theodicy survives—Job's sincerity, which vindicates nothing by argument and everything by integrity of practice.

The series transposes the problem. It asks not whether God can be justified before evil, but whether humanity can be justified before its own: an *anthropodicy*. And it accepts Kant's verdict that such a justification cannot be argued. It can only be enacted, and the medium of enactment is play. Each antagonist is a prosecutor who argues a philosophical anthropology; each game is the defense, conducted not by counterargument but by the protagonist's—and the player's—conduct over a year.

Prosecutor	Game	Accusation	Philosophical lineage	Answer enacted in play
Nyarlathotep	*P2*	Given power over its own reality, humanity destroys itself	Hobbes; Schopenhauer; Lovecraft	Bonds surrendered to save the world; Maya's chosen hope
Erebus, summoning Nyx	*P3*	Humanity secretly desires death	Freud; Spielrein; Schopenhauer	Death acknowledged and given, neither desired nor denied
Izanami	*P4*	Humanity prefers comforting illusion	Plato; Lacan; Sloterdijk	Truth sought in common (qualified in Chapter 5)
Yaldabaoth	*P5*	Humanity wishes to be ruled	La Boétie; Dostoevsky; Fromm; Kant	Plural power: the public's renewed belief
Maruki	*Royal*	Humanity wants happiness without pain	Bentham; Huxley; Nozick; Nietzsche	Pain chosen; the proper name reclaimed

The sequence has a direction. The accusations move from the cosmic and metaphysical (self-destruction, death) through the epistemic (illusion) to the political (servitude) and finally the therapeutic (painless happiness). The last prosecutor is the most humane, and therefore the most dangerous: Maruki accuses humanity of nothing but suffering, and offers to end it. *Royal*'s answer reprises Candide's. Haru tends a vegetable garden on the school roof; the counsel to cultivate one's garden, a refusal of the best of all possible worlds in favor of a finite labor, is the game's last word against its kindest enemy.

9.3 The juridical arc of the series

Read across its titles and frames, the series is a trial of humanity conducted in procedural stages. *Innocent Sin* names the offense; *Eternal Punishment* names the sentence. *P3* imposes a sentence of death and converts it into an eternal sealing. *P4* is an investigation, its heroes an "Investigation Team." *P5* is an interrogation and a probation: the whole game is testimony before a prosecutor, and its hero is a probationer. *Royal*

is an appeal against clemency, in which the accused refuses a merciful verdict that would abolish both guilt and grief.

In this court the player is the advocate. The Greek *paraklētos* names the counsel for the defense, the one called to stand beside the accused. Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915) tells of a man who waits all his life before a door and learns at the end that it was meant only for him. The Velvet Room's door, whose key is given only to the protagonist, is that door opened: the law addresses each player singly, and the defense is conducted in person.

9.4 The return of the mask and the trance

Why must the defense take the form of play? Roger Caillois classified games by four principles—*agôn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation and masks) and *ilinx* (vertigo)—and argued that archaic societies were governed by the alliance of mimicry and ilinx, the mask and the trance, whereas civilization begins when that alliance gives way to agôn and alea, merit and luck (*Les Jeux et les hommes*, 1958). The *Persona* series is a Cailloisian atavism. It reinstalls the archaic complex of mask and trance—summoning is possession; the Evoker's shot is induced vertigo—inside the most agonistic institution of modern Japan, the school with its examinations and published rankings, and alongside aleatory mechanics (Shuffle Time, the Fortune Arcanum, the casino Palace).

The anthropodicy depends on this return. Humanity is not vindicated by merit, which the games reward but never sanctify, nor by luck, which they mock, but by the capacity to be possessed by others and to risk the dissolution of the self—mimicry and ilinx reclaimed as ethical rather than primitive powers. Chapter 10 will give that capacity its biological name.

9.5 The player as Wild Card, and the limits of the bet

The silent protagonist, named by the player and voiceless in dialogue, enacts Barthes's "death of the author" (1967) as game design: the birth of the player is purchased at the cost of the protagonist's speech. The evidence in humanity's defense is, finally, a real person's sustained attention across a hundred hours. When the verdict arrives, it passes into

the player's hands; the bet was placed on the person holding the controller.

The structure has a cost. A wager that singles out one Wild Card risks collapsing anthropodicy into the meritocratic romance of the exceptional individual: humanity vindicated by its chosen son. The series resists this collapse whenever its final power is collective—the Universe made of bonds, the public's belief summoning Satanael—and succumbs to it whenever the women of will are relegated to the margins and the center remains a single male avatar. The correction cannot come from the wager itself. It requires a different theory of how humans change.

9.6 The year as rite of passage

The fourth operator, Metamorphosis, has a social form before it has a biological one, and the series builds that form into its calendar. Arnold van Gennep showed that rites of passage move through separation, a liminal margin and reincorporation (*Les Rites de passage*, 1909). Victor Turner described the liminal phase as a condition "betwixt and between" assigned positions, in which initiands shed their status, are often masked or disguised, and form an egalitarian bond he called *communitas* (1967; *The Ritual Process*, 1969).

From *P3* onward, each game is a rite of passage in exactly this sense. In separation, the protagonist arrives as a transfer student from elsewhere, without his parents, at the start of the Japanese school year in April. In the margin, he lives for a year between the ordinary school and a liminal Otherworld—the Dark Hour, the television, the Metaverse—entered at thresholds (a clock passing midnight, a screen, a phone app), where he and his companions wear masks and code names and form the communitas of SEES, the Investigation Team and the Phantom Thieves. In reincorporation, the year ends in March with graduation and cherry blossoms, and the protagonist departs: by train in *P4*, by car in *P5*, and in *P3* by death on graduation day, the one reincorporation that cannot be completed.

Bakhtin's account of carnival explains why the margin is also a space of inversion: in the Palaces the powerful are crowned and uncrowned, and the Fool of Arcanum 0 leads (*Rabelais and His World*, 1965). The

Japanese calendar explains why the passage carries the pathos of *mono no aware*: the school year is bounded by blossoms that fall. The rite, however, describes only the frame of transformation—its entry, its margin and its exit. It says nothing about what happens to the self inside the margin. Chapter 10 supplies that interior: the chrysalis is the liminal phase seen from within.

X



Part Four: Synthesis

Toward a Chrysalid Humanism

The series' humanism can be completed rather than repeated only by changing its governing image of transformation: from the hero who slays and the mask that is torn away, to the chrysalis that dissolves and recomposes.

10.1 What the reconstruction requires

The preceding chapters reconstructed an imaginal humanism generated by four operators—Mask, Bond, Wager, Metamorphosis—and identified its limits. The matricidal archive (Chapter 7) installs the feminine as origin, apocalypse, medium and casing, but rarely as subject. The wager (Chapter 9) drifts toward the romance of the exceptional individual. The ethic of truth (Chapter 5) forces Shadows into the open before witnesses and cannot distinguish liberation from exposure. What is required is a theory of transformation that does not require matricide, that is collective rather than heroic, and that treats opacity as a condition rather than an obstacle. The series already contains the image of such a theory. It has been flying over its protagonists since 1996.

10.2 The entomology of the self

The Western vocabulary of selfhood is entomological at its root. Latin *larva* meant a ghost, a malevolent spirit of the dead, and a mask; Linnaeus borrowed it for the immature insect on the ground that the caterpillar masks the adult form. Latin *pupa* meant a girl and a doll; the swaddled chrysalis suggested a doll in its wrappings. Latin *imago* meant an image, and specifically the wax death-masks of ancestors that Roman noble families kept in their atria and that actors wore at funerals to impersonate the dead (Polybius 6.53; Pliny, *Natural History* 35.6). It names the adult insect and, since Jung borrowed it from Carl Spitteler's novel *Imago* (1906), the unconscious prototype of a person within the psyche. Greek *psychē* names both soul and butterfly; Aristotle uses it of a moth (*Historia animalium* V.19). Greek *chrysallis* derives from *chrysos*, gold: the pupa is "the golden one," and the alchemists, whose sealed vessel transmuted base matter into gold under Mercurius, are its natural theorists.

Read as a sequence, the lexicon tells a story the series has been telling without knowing it. The human begins as *larva*: a mask, a ghost, Descartes advancing onto the world's stage *larvatus*. It ends as *imago*: an image, an ancestral face, an adult. Between them lies the *pupa*: the girl, the doll. The passage from mask to image runs through the girl. This is the occluded middle term of the series' metamorphic humanism, the position occupied by Maki's imagination, by the gynoid Aigis, by the attendants of the Velvet Room, by Labrys and the artificial Sophia, by Sumire living inside her sister's shoe. The series has consistently placed the feminine at the pupal stage, as the casing within which another's transformation occurs. Chrysalid humanism begins by asking what the casing is.

10.3 Psyche against Orpheus

The mythic charter for that question exists. In Apuleius's *Metamorphoses* (second century CE, Books IV–VI), Psyche is married to an invisible husband and forbidden to look at him. She lights a lamp, sees that he is Cupid, spills a drop of oil, and he flees. What follows is the antithesis of Izanagi's flight and Orpheus's loss. Psyche does not flee and is not lost; she labors. Venus sets her four tasks—sorting a mountain of mixed seeds, gathering golden wool from violent rams, drawing water from the Styx, and descending to the underworld for a box of Proserpina's beauty—and she accomplishes each with help: ants, a whispering reed, Jupiter's eagle, a speaking tower. Returning, she opens the box and falls into a death-like sleep; Cupid wakes her; she is made immortal; their daughter is named Voluptas.

Erich Neumann, who codified the matricidal monomyth, devoted a separate study to this tale, *Amor and Psyche: The Psychic Development of the Feminine* (1952), reading Psyche's look as an act of feminine consciousness that breaks the paradise of unconscious union. Feminist Jungians have rightly objected that Neumann still directs Psyche's development toward reunion with a masculine principle (Wehr 1987; Rowland 2002). The structure of the tale nonetheless exceeds his interpretation and supplies everything the series' dominant myths lack. In Izanagi's myth and Orpheus's, a man looks and loses, and the woman is sealed away. In Psyche's, a woman looks and errs, and her error begins

her individuation rather than ending it. Her individuation is assisted: the ants, the reed, the eagle and the tower are nonhuman companions, the Koromaru, Teddie and Morgana of antiquity. It passes through a descent and a return, the pattern Sylvia Brinton Perera drew from the descent of Inanna (1981), and through a death that proves to be sleep. And it ends not in the defeat of a mother but in a birth.

The series' recurring emblem is the azure butterfly associated with Philemon. In Greek, that butterfly is Psyche. The male guardian of the series wears, as his sign, the soul-as-woman whose story the series has not yet told.

10.4 Histolysis, imaginal discs and the memory of the caterpillar

The biology of complete metamorphosis gives the myth its mechanism. Within the pupa of a holometabolous insect, much of the larval body is broken down by programmed cell death (histolysis). The adult is built largely from imaginal discs: clusters of cells set aside in the larva, in some species already in the embryo, which remain quiescent through larval life and proliferate in the pupa. The popular image of a caterpillar dissolving into undifferentiated soup exaggerates. Parts of the nervous system persist and are remodeled, and experiments have shown that moths can retain an aversion learned as late-stage caterpillars (Blackiston, Silva Casey and Weiss 2008). Four propositions translate these facts into theses about the human.

First, the future is present from the beginning, but not as the larva's own: the imaginal discs are set apart, dormant, other within the self. In the series' terms they are the bonds. Watsuji's betweenness is ontologically prior to the ego's awareness of it; the Social Links do not add others to a finished self but activate the others already set aside within it.

Second, transformation requires dissolution. Spielrein's destruction as the cause of coming into being, Caillois's *ilinx*, the vertigo of the Evoker, the confrontation with the Shadow: each names a necessary undoing of the prior form. Dissolution is not death. Something persists, so that the adult remembers what the larva learned.

Third, transformation requires closure. A chrysalis opened from outside before its time does not release a butterfly; it kills the creature in the middle of becoming. Glissant's right to opacity is therefore not an exception to transformation but its condition. The Midnight Channel, which broadcasts Kanji's and Naoto's unfinished selves to a town, is an apparatus for opening chrysalises.

Fourth, the casing is not a container. The pupa is not a vessel holding an adult but the organism itself in its most radical activity. The pupal feminine is not the vessel of another's transformation; it is transformation. The doll is the one who is changing.

10.5 Six theses

Chrysalid humanism may now be stated as six theses, each written against a position the dissertation has examined.

1. **Against essence and against solitary self-authorship.** The human is neither an individual substance of rational nature (Boethius) nor a freedom that makes itself alone, whether as Pico's chameleon or as the Sartrean project in which existence precedes essence (1946). It is a metamorphic capacity: the capacity to be dissolved and recomposed through others, with memory retained.
2. **Against matricide.** Individuation does not require slaying the mother. Its paradigm is Psyche's sequence—look, err, labor, descend, return—undertaken with others. The series' maternal apocalypses (Pandora, Nyx, Izanami) are better read as pupal powers misrecognized as devourers: the dissolution they threaten is the dissolution transformation requires, and the error is to meet it with a single hero rather than to undergo it in common.
3. **Against unmasking.** The end of the mask is neither the naked face nor nothing. *Royal*'s third-tier Personas show that the terminal metamorphosis of a mask is a proper name: Arendt's "who," Cavarero's narratable self. Masks are larval; they are to be metamorphosed, not torn off.

4. **Against compulsory transparency.** Transformation requires protected opacity. The ethic of the Midnight Channel, truth by exposure before witnesses, must give way to an ethic of the closed chrysalis: witness without exposure, presence without broadcast.
5. **Against care as repair.** Care is co-metamorphosis: Tronto's caring-with, Weil's attention. Maruki's unilateral repair opens every chrysalis from outside and fixes each self in a final form it did not reach by itself.
6. **Against the exceptional individual.** The Wild Card is not a chosen son but a function that can be inherited, transferred and shared, as Aigis inherits it. Its truest form is the one *P3* named: a universe made of bonds.

10.6 Among the humanisms

Chrysalid humanism takes a position among existing humanisms. With the Renaissance humanists it holds that the human has no fixed seat, but it replaces the chameleon, which changes its surface, with the chrysalis, which changes its substance. With Beauvoir it holds that one is not born but becomes (*Le Deuxième Sexe*, 1949), but it reclaims becoming from imposition, as a metamorphosis undergone with others rather than a form pressed on from outside. It accepts the antihumanist critiques of the sovereign subject: Foucault's image of man erased "like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea" (*Les Mots et les choses*, 1966) describes, from the chrysalid standpoint, not an ending but a histolysis. It shares Fanon's demand, at the close of *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961), that the decolonized work out new concepts and set afoot a new humanity; Levinas's humanism of the other human (1972); and Said's critical humanism (2004). With posthumanism (Haraway 1985, 2003; Braidotti 2013) it declines to bind the human to a species, since dogs, bears, cats and gynoids awaken Personas. And it distinguishes itself from Catherine Malabou's "destructive plasticity," transformation by trauma that produces a stranger without continuity (*Ontologie de l'accident*, 2009). The Lost of *P3* and the recipients of Maruki's reality are subjects of destructive

plasticity; chrysalid transformation differs because the caterpillar's memory survives.

Japanese literature supplies the decisive comparisons. Enchi Fumiko's *Onnamen* (*Masks*, 1958) organizes its chapters around Noh masks and gives its heroine, Mieko Togano, a hidden power over the men around her that operates, like Lady Rokujō's spirit, in the dark. Enchi shows that opacity can shelter revenge as well as transformation, so chrysalid humanism must distinguish the opacity of the pupa, which ends in emergence, from the opacity of the Shadow, which ends in possession. Murata Sayaka's *Konbini ningen* (*Convenience Store Woman*, 2016) supplies the counter-case: Keiko Furukura assembles a persona by copying her coworkers' speech and dress and the store's manual, a mask that never pupates. Between Enchi's vengeful opacity and Murata's larval conformity lies the chrysalis.

10.7 The chrysalid Wild Card

The series' unrealized protagonist can now be reconstructed. The mainline Wild Card is larval. The larval stage is the feeding stage, and the Wild Card's appetite for Personas—acquired, fused, discarded, fused again—is a caterpillar's appetite. The chrysalid Wild Card would hold the metamorphoses of others in protected opacity and undergo its own in common. The corpus has already drawn the figure in fragments. Maya Amano chooses hope after her own death. Aigis inherits the Wild Card from a sealed boy while the swallowed Metis returns from within her. Elizabeth leaves the Velvet Room to descend. The heroine of *Portable* lives the whole year and is then removed from the remake. Futaba asks for her own transformation, the first figure in the series to choose her chrysalis. Sumire passes from a borrowed slipper to her own name. Labrys accepts the Minotaur inside the abandoned princess.

These women of will are, in a further sense, thieves. Alicia Ostriker called the women poets who rewrote classical myth "thieves of language" (1982), and Hélène Cixous played on the double meaning of French *voler*, to fly and to steal, aligning women with birds and robbers (1975). The Phantom Thieves steal hearts; the chrysalid Wild Card steals back the

myths. Her emblem joins both senses of *voler*: the thief who flies is the butterfly.

The player stands inside the same structure. Huizinga's magic circle is a chrysalis: opaque to the outside world, temporary, protective, a space in which the player's self partly dissolves into a silent avatar and recomposes over a hundred hours. The melancholy that many players report on finishing a *Persona* game is the experience of emergence. The casing has opened, and the imago must fly in a world that did not watch it change.

XXI



Part Four: Synthesis

Conclusion: Thou Art I, Otherwise

The *Persona* series has made the mask think; it has not yet let the chrysalis speak. That sentence condenses the dissertation's two arguments, the reconstructive and the critical, and the proposal that joins them.

The reconstructive argument showed that the series transvalues Jung's persona from concealing façade into expressive mask, in the line of Wilde and Yeats, and builds upon it an imaginal humanism generated by four operators. The Mask is the interface through which a self appears to others and acts among them, Arendt's daimon visible over the shoulder. The Bond is the transindividual medium of recognition, Watsuji's *aidagara* rendered as procedure and Weil's attention rendered as a calendar. The Wager is a ludic anthropodicy, in which a sequence of prosecutorial gods —Nyarlathotep, Erebus, Izanami, Yaldabaoth, Maruki—argue that humanity desires its own destruction, death, illusion, servitude and anesthesia, and in which the only possible defense is a year of conduct. Metamorphosis is the form of the school year as rite of passage. Each cycle articulates a distinct philosophical anthropology: an ontology of rumor, a thanatology, an epistemology, a politics, and finally a critique of therapy.

The critical argument showed that this humanism rests on a matricidal archive. Its apocalypses are mothers; its machines run on women's imagination and knowledge; its navigators are women and animals; its women of will live at the margins of the canon, in optional scenarios, portable editions, expansions and spin-offs. The fiction reproduces the Matilda effect of its own genealogy, from Spielrein's footnote to the uncredited painters of its tarot to the daughter of Wollstonecraft whose heroines staff the Velvet Room. Yet the series also harbors its own counter-testimony. Its compendium of mythic names—Yamato-Takeru, Kanzeon, Rokuten Maō, Metis, Isis, Amaterasu, Astarte, Agnes—says what its scripts refuse to say. By the series' own law, a Shadow acknowledged becomes power. This dissertation has attempted that acknowledgment on the series' behalf.

The proposal that results is chrysalid humanism: the human as the capacity to dissolve one's form in relation and to be recomposed by the imaginal presence of others, with memory retained and in protected opacity, on the model of Psyche rather than Orpheus and of the pupa

rather than the larva or the imago. Its paradigmatic subject is the chrysalid Wild Card, whom the series has drawn in fragments but never placed at its center.

The series' central incantation can now be revised. "I am thou, thou art I" collapses the other into identity. Aristotle's "another self," Buber's Thou and Watsuji's betweenness each preserve a difference that the formula elides. The chrysalid revision would read: *thou art I, otherwise*. The other is within me not as my mirror but as an imaginal disc, set apart and dormant until a bond activates it; I become myself through thee only by becoming other than I was; and thou dost the same through me.

The epigraphs return transformed. Descartes advanced *larvatus*, and the word was more exact than he knew: the modern subject entered the world as a larva. Nietzsche held that everything profound loves a mask; the mask is the larval form of depth, and depth is what the larva becomes when it is allowed to close itself away and change. Hiratsuka Raichō wrote that woman was once the sun and had become a pale moon shining by another's light. In the chrysalid reading, the moon-phase is not woman's final condition but her pupal one. Yukiko's Amaterasu is the series' small proof that the sun can re-emerge.

Three lines of further research follow. The method of onomastic reading can be extended to other compendium-based media, in which databases of mythic names carry meanings their narratives do not authorize. The remake, as *Reload*'s omission of the *Portable* heroine shows, is a privileged site at which canons decide which women of will survive, and deserves study as such. And the dissertation's account of the Social Link as a pedagogy of attention invites empirical work on how players' instrumental motives are, or are not, transformed into care.

The series began with a girl's dream appropriated by a corporate machine. It has reached, so far, a girl reclaiming her own name. Between those two figures lies the chrysalis: neither mask nor face, but the dark and golden place in which a human being is unmade and remade by others, and from which it emerges—if the casing is not torn open too soon—with its memory intact and its wings still wet.

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Persona series; Atlus; Japanese role-playing games; game studies; procedural rhetoric; ludonarrative dissonance; imaginal humanism; chrysalid humanism; matricidal archive; onomastic reading; ludic anthropodicy; theodicy; analytical psychology; C. G. Jung; Kawai Hayao; Watsuji Tetsurō; *aidagara*; *omote* and *ura*; Yogācāra; Kyoto School; persona; mask; Shadow; Wild Card; individuation; Social Link; ethics of care; recognition; attention; Hannah Arendt; trickster; Gnosticism; Yaldabaoth; tarot; *Frankenstein*; *Kojiki*; Izanami; death drive; Sabina Spielrein; Matilda effect; Toni Wolff; medial woman; feminist theory; queer theory; gender performativity; male gaze; right to opacity; metamorphosis; Psyche; posthumanism; Japanese popular culture.